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CHAPTER 5: RESULTS

Introduction

This chapter presents the results of the quantitative analysis conducted to test the ten hypotheses stated in chapter3 and to provide an answer to the five research questions. Consistent with the analytical approach set out in Chapter 4, the results are reported with sparse commentary; their interpretation against the literature is reserved for Chapter 6. The chapter follows the sequence recommended for partial least squares structural equation modelling (PLS-SEM) reporting (Hair et al., 2022). Section 5.2 describes the data screening and the sample obtained. Section 5.3 reports the descriptive statistics. Section 5.4 sets out the data transformations and the deviations between the approved and the fielded instrument. Section 5.5 reports the assessment of the reflective measurement model, and Section 5.6 addresses common method and non-response bias. Section 5.7 assesses the structural model, after which Sections 5.8 to 5.11 report the results per research question and hypothesis. Section 5.12 reports supplementary and robustness analyses, and Section 5.13 summarises the hypothesis outcomes. In order to ensure the organisation of the results for improved understanding and clarity, the results are categorised into different stages based on data screening, descriptive statistics, measurement model evaluation, structural model evaluation, hypothesis testing, and robustness testing. All the sub-sections of the results clearly mention the research question/hypothesis that is being tested through that section. All the tables and figures are appropriately labelled with numbers and names under Chapter 5. The chapter concludes with a consolidated summary of the hypothesis-testing outcomes and the explanatory and predictive performance of the integrated model.

5.2 Description of the sample obtained

5.2.1 Data collection and screening

The questionnaire was administered between 11 August 2026 and 12 October 2026 through the mixed-mode distribution described in section 4.10. A total of 201 survey records were received. As shown in Table 1, one respondent was excluded for being under 18 years of age, 23 respondents were excluded because they did not live in Gauteng, and 56 respondents were excluded because they were aged 36 years or older. This ensured that the sample consisted of the target population of young people aged 18 to 35 years living in Gauteng. One respondent indicated being younger than 18 years and was routed out of the survey, and 23 respondents indicated that they did not live in Gauteng. A further 56 respondents selected an age band of 36 years and above. These respondents fell

outside the study's definition of youth (18 to 35 years) and provided no construct data, so they were excluded. Consequently, 121 eligible respondents entered the construct sections of the questionnaire.

Of the 121 eligible respondents who entered the construct sections, seven had more than 15% of construct items missing and were excluded, in line with the threshold set in Chapter 4. No case showed straight-line responding: the smallest within-case standard deviation across the Likert-type construct items was 0.48, so no case was removed on that criterion. The final analytic sample therefore comprised 114 respondents. Across this sample, 43 of the 3192 Likert-type item responses were missing and were treated by mean replacement. The median completion time was approximately five minutes and twenty seconds (Hair et al., 2022). The sampling screening is clearly explained in Table 1, which shows how the 201 survey records were reduced to the sample size of 114. The information helps in setting the ground for the statistical analysis and allows one to evaluate the amount of data screening that was done.

Table 1 Sample screening and data cleaning

Screening step	**n**
Total survey records received	201
Excluded: under 18 years of age	1
Excluded: not resident in Gauteng	23
Excluded: aged 36 and above (outside the 18–35 definition of youth)	56
Eligible respondents who entered the construct sections	121
Excluded: more than 15% of construct items missing	7
Excluded: straight-line responding (zero within-case variance)	0
Final analytic sample	114

The final sample of 114 fell below the a priori target of 150 valid responses set in section 4.8; however, it exceeded the minimum of 110 required by the ten-times rule calculated in section 4.8 (Hair et al., 2022). By the inverse square root method (Kock & Hadaya, 2018), a sample of 114 is sufficient at the 5% significance level and 80% power to detect path coefficients of approximately 0.23 or larger. This is slightly above the approximate detection threshold of 0.20 associated with the planned sample of 150 described in Chapter 4, indicating that the smaller achieved sample may limit the detection of weaker relationships. The implications of the shortfall for statistical power, particularly

for the interaction effects tested under H9 and H10, are noted where relevant in this chapter and discussed further in chapters 6 and 7. However, the shortage in terms of the intended sample size is recognised as a methodological limitation, especially as far as the interaction effects examined under H9 and H10 are concerned. The conclusions drawn on the basis of these hypotheses are thus cautiously considered.

5.2.2 Demographic profile of respondents

Table 2 presents the demographic characteristics of the 114 respondents included in the final analysis. The sample was reasonably distributed across the three youth age bands, with 25.4% aged 18 to 24, 36.8% aged 25 to 29, and 37.7% aged 30 to 35. Female respondents made up 48.2% of the sample and male respondents 31.6%. A further 9.6% identified as non-binary, and 10.5% preferred not to state their gender. The sample was highly educated: 57% held a bachelor's degree or higher, including 29.8% with a postgraduate qualification and 6.1% with a doctorate, while 6.1% had not completed matric. University graduates made up 43.9% and were the most common type of institution most recently attended, and 16.7% were not currently or recently studying. Almost half of the respondents (49.1%) reported that a member of their immediate family had owned or run a business.

Table 2 Demographic profile of respondents (n = 114)

Characteristic	n	%
Age band		
18–24 years	29	25.4
25–29 years	42	36.8
30–35 years	43	37.7
Gender		
Female	55	48.2
Male	36	31.6
Non-binary	11	9.6
Prefer not to say	12	10.5
Highest qualification		
Below matric	7	6.1
Matric	21	18.4
Certificate or diploma	21	18.4
Bachelor's degree	24	21.1
Postgraduate	34	29.8

Characteristic	n	%
Doctorate	7	6.1
Institution most recently attended		
University	50	43.9
University of Technology	15	13.2
TVET college	14	12.3
Private institution	15	13.2
Not currently or recently studying	19	16.7
Family business background		
Yes	56	49.1
No	39	34.2
Not sure / maybe	18	15.8
Current situation (multiple responses permitted)		
Own or operate a business	68	59.6
Intend to start a business within 24 months	76	66.7
Enrolled in an entrepreneurship programme	52	45.6

The screening item on current situation was fielded as a multiple-response item rather than as the single-choice item that assigned respondents to one of the four strata in Annexure B of the ethics application. Of the 114 respondents, 82 selected two categories and 32 selected one and no respondent selected “none of these”. Overall, 59.6% reported owning or operating a business, 66.7% intended to start a business within 24 months, and 45.6% were enrolled in an entrepreneurship program. Strata membership was therefore overlapping, and the fourth stratum (the broader youth segment without entrepreneurial exposure) was not separately represented. The multiple-response format of the current-situation question requires clarification when interpreting the sample profile.

5.3 Descriptive statistics

5.3.1 Item-level descriptive statistics

Table 3 reports the means, standard deviations, skewness, and excess kurtosis for the Likert-type items included in the fielded questionnaire. All items were scored from 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree). Item means ranged from 2.94 (F2) to 4.27 (B1), and most items were negatively skewed, indicating a general tendency towards agreement. The highest means were recorded for the passion items B1 (4.27), B4 (4.04) and B2 (4.04) and for H5 (4.09). The lowest means were recorded for the socio-structural

items G1 (3.13) and G2 (3.02) and for the outcome expectation items F2 (2.94) and F3 (3.28). Skewness values fell between −1.66 and −0.08 and excess kurtosis between −1.38 and 2.36, within the commonly used ±2 and ±7 bounds for univariate normality, although several items departed from normality.

Reason for the changes: B4 is listed as 4.04 in Table 5.3, and the skewness values in that table range from −1.66 to −0.08. The narrative should match the table. These results describe variation in the perception of entrepreneurial passion, perceived environmental support, and expected entrepreneurial outcomes among respondents. Yet the results are merely descriptive and thus should not be used as proof of any statistically significant relationship between these constructs.

Table 3 Item-level descriptive statistics (n = 114)

Item	Statement	M	SD	Skew	Kurt.
B1	I feel a strong passion for entrepreneurial activities	4.27	1.10	−1.66	2.16
B2	Starting or growing a business is something I am passionate about	4.04	0.91	−0.86	0.43
B3	I keep working on entrepreneurial activities even when they become difficult	3.63	1.21	−0.44	−0.89
B4	Entrepreneurship motivates me to grow my skills and knowledge	4.04	0.99	−1.32	1.73
B5	Being involved in building a business is an important part of who I am	3.65	1.25	−0.79	−0.28
C1	I am confident in my ability to spot gaps in the market	3.78	1.04	−0.85	0.29
C2	I have the knowledge and skills needed to start a business	3.73	1.14	−0.64	−0.50
C3	I am confident I could manage the finances of a business	3.75	1.06	−0.66	−0.25
C4	I am confident I could start a business even against difficult odds	3.58	1.14	−0.51	−0.50
C5	I am confident I could recover from setbacks in a business venture	3.66	1.14	−0.74	−0.15
D1	My family encourages and supports my business ambitions	3.81	1.14	−0.86	0.06
D2	My friends and peers view entrepreneurship positively	3.75	1.06	−0.71	−0.02
D4	I have access to mentors or advisors I could turn to	3.56	1.25	−0.60	−0.57
D5	Organisations in my community actively support people starting businesses	3.28	1.18	−0.24	−1.01
E1	I know of successful entrepreneurs who come from a background similar to mine	3.79	1.17	−0.79	−0.35
E2	I have seen entrepreneurs succeed despite facing serious challenges	4.01	1.03	−0.97	0.48
E3	I have access to entrepreneurial role models in my community	3.58	1.14	−0.48	−0.49

Item	Statement	M	SD	Skew	Kurt.
E4	Hearing the stories of other entrepreneurs makes me believe I could do it too	3.88	1.17	−0.97	0.08
F2	Running my own business would earn me respect from people whose opinion I value	2.94	1.27	−0.12	−1.05
F3	Building a business would make me proud of myself	3.28	1.54	−0.36	−1.38
F4	The rewards of starting a business would outweigh the risks I would take on	3.72	1.10	−0.57	−0.23
G1	I can access the funding and financial resources needed to start a business	3.13	1.22	−0.08	−0.86
G2	Government policies and programmes make it easier for young people to start businesses	3.02	1.18	−0.14	−0.72
G5	The current South African business environment makes it difficult to start a business (raw score, before reversal)	3.67	1.06	−0.67	0.03
H1	I am considering starting a business within the next three years	3.90	1.08	−0.91	0.23
H3	I am more determined to create a business venture than to find employment	3.73	1.13	−0.78	0.05
H4	My professional goal is to become an entrepreneur	3.81	1.16	−0.79	−0.15
H5	I am motivated to develop the knowledge and skills needed to run a business	4.09	1.03	−1.53	2.36

M = mean; SD = standard deviation; Kurt. = excess kurtosis. Items D3 and F5 in the approved instrument were not included in the fielded questionnaire. Items F1, G3, G4 and H2 were fielded with Yes/No response options and are reported separately in Table 5.3.

Four items were fielded with split Yes/No response options rather than the five-point scale specified in the approved instrument. Their response distributions are reported in Table 4. Most respondents (84.1%) expected that starting a business would give them a better financial future than employment, and 65.2% reported that they already had plans in place to start a business. In contrast, only 38.6% reported that business incubators and supplier development programs were available to them.

Table 4 Distribution of items fielded with dichotomous response options (n = 114)

Item	Statement	% Yes
F1	Starting a business would give me a better financial future than being employed	84.1
G3	Business incubators and supplier development programmes are available to me	38.6
G4	The general social climate encourages young people to pursue entrepreneurship	64.6
H2	I already have plans in place to start a business	65.2

5.3.2 Construct-level descriptive statistics

Table 5 reports the descriptive statistics for each construct, computed as the mean of the items retained after the measurement model assessment in section 5.5. entrepreneurial passion recorded the highest mean (M=3.93, SD= 0.86), followed by entrepreneurial role model (M = 3.89, SD = 0.87) and entrepreneurial intention (M = 3.81, SD = 0.84). Socio-structural facilitators recorded the lowest mean (M = 3.08, SD = 0.99), close to the scale midpoint, indicating that respondents on average perceived the funding and policy environment as neither enabling nor obstructive. The Shapiro- Wilk test rejected univariate normality for every construct ($p < .01$). This supports the choice of PLS-SEM, which does not require normally distributed data (Hair et al., 2022).

Table 5 Construct-level descriptive statistics (n = 114)

Construct	Items	M	SD	Skew	Kurt.	Shapiro-Wilk p
Entrepreneurial passion (EP)	5	3.93	0.86	−0.80	0.29	< .001
Entrepreneurial self-efficacy (ESE)	4	3.69	0.83	−0.21	−0.53	.006
Social support (SS)	3	3.71	0.86	−0.65	0.18	< .001
Entrepreneurial role models (RM)	3	3.89	0.87	−0.67	−0.05	< .001
Outcome expectations (OE)	1	3.72	1.10	−0.57	−0.23	< .001
Socio-structural facilitators (SF)	2	3.08	0.99	−0.25	−0.62	.001
Entrepreneurial intention (EI)	3	3.81	0.84	−0.70	0.28	< .001

Note. Construct scores are the unweighted means of retained items.

5.4 Data transformations and deviations from the approved instrument

Three data transformations were applied before the analysis. First, the text responses were converted to numeric scores from 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree). The labels “neither agree nor disagree” and “neutral”, which appeared on different items of the field questionnaire, were both coded as 3. Second, item G5, which concerned the difficulty of the current South African business environment, was reverse-scored (6 minus the raw score) so that higher values denoted a more enabling perceived environment, as specified in section 4.9.2. Third, missing values on retained cases were replaced with the item mean, as reported in section 5.2.1. For the control variables, age band was coded ordinally (1 = 18 to 24.2 = 25 to 29.3 = 30 to 35). Gender was coded as a dummy variable (1 = female, 0 = all other responses), as was family entrepreneurial background (1 = yes, 0 = no or not sure). Institution type was coded as 1 for a university or university of technology and 0 for all other responses. Comparison of the dataset with the instrument approved in the ethical clearance application identified four deviations that affected the analysis:

- The fielded questionnaire contained 32 construct items rather than 34; item D3 “My community views entrepreneurship as a respectable path” and item F5 “Running my own business would allow me to contribute meaningfully to my community” were not included.
- Items F1, G3, G4 and H2 were fielded with Yes/No response options. Split indicators do not meet the interval level assumption underlying reflective measurement on a common Likert-type metric, so these four items were excluded from the reflective measurement models. They were retained descriptively (Table 5.4) and tested in the robustness analyses in section 5.12.
- The gender item included a non-binary option and the family business item a “maybe” option that did not appear in the approved instrument. These responses were retained and coded as described above. These deviations are reported explicitly because they affect the operationalisation of the constructs, the comparability of the response categories, and the interpretation of the sample characteristics.
- The current situation item permitted multiple selections, so the four strata were not mutually exclusive (section 5.2.2).

5.5 Assessment of the measurement model

The reflective measurement model was assessed before any structural relationship was interpreted (Hair et al., 2022). The model was estimated with the PLS-SEM algorithm using the path weighting scheme and standardised indicators. Inference was based on bootstrapping with 5000 subsamples and bias-corrected and accelerated (BCa) 95% confidence intervals.

5.5.1 Indicator reliability and item purification

Table 6 reports the outer loadings for the initial model, which contained all Likert-type items, and for the final model after item purification. The five passion items all exceeded the 0.708 threshold in the initial model. In contrast, the outcome expectations and socio-structural facilitators constructs showed serious problems. Item F2 and F3 loaded negatively (-0.559 and -0.407) on the outcome expectations construct. Neither item correlated meaningfully with another construct item; their correlations with the remaining 26 items ranged between -0.31 and 0.23 and were mostly close to zero. Item G5, after reversal, loaded negatively (-0.744) on the socio-structural facilitators construct, indicating that the reverse-worded item did not behave consistently with the positively worded G1 and G2. In this initial model, the composite reliabilities of outcome expectations (0.005)

and socio-structural facilitators (0.084) were far below the acceptable range. On this basis, F2, F3 and G5 were removed for negative loadings. C3 (0.618), D5 (0.529) and E3 (0.586) were removed because the AVEs of entrepreneurial self-efficacy (0.494 before C3 was removed), social support (0.476) and role models (0.511, marginal) were raised as a result. Reason for the change: The value 0.949 is inconsistent with the reported indicator loadings and the final ESE AVE of 0.554. Based on the initial ESE loadings shown in Table 5.6, the initial AVE is approximately 0.494; after C3 was removed, the reported final AVE is 0.554. H5 “I am motivated to develop the knowledge and skills needed to run a business” also refers to a learning goal rather than to the intended behaviour of starting a venture. Its removal therefore aligns the measure more closely with the compatibility principle discussed in section 2.2.1 the final model retained indicators according to their statistical performance and conceptual relevance rather than applying a mechanical loading threshold alone. After purification, outcome expectations were measured by a single item (F4) and socio-structural facilitators by two items (G1 and G2). Three retained indicators loaded slightly below 0.708: E1 (0.657), D2 (0.689), and C1 (0.692). They were retained because their constructs met the AVE and composite reliability criteria, which Hair et al. (2022) and Ajzen, (2020) identify as the condition for retaining indicators in the 0.40 to 0.708 range. The variance inflation factors of all retained indicators were below 3.0 (maximum 2.594 for B2), so indicator collinearity was not a concern.

Table 6 Outer loadings in the initial and final measurement models

Construct	Item	Initial loading	Final loading	Decision
Entrepreneurial passion	B1	0.779	0.784	Retained
	B2	0.871	0.866	Retained
	B3	0.747	0.756	Retained
	B4	0.760	0.747	Retained
	B5	0.798	0.801	Retained
Entrepreneurial self-efficacy	C1	0.680	0.692	Retained
	C2	0.700	0.716	Retained
	C3	0.618	–	Removed
	C4	0.763	0.798	Retained
	C5	0.745	0.766	Retained
Social support	D1	0.769	0.804	Retained
	D2	0.749	0.689	Retained
	D4	0.686	0.743	Retained

Construct	Item	Initial loading	Final loading	Decision
	D5	0.529	–	Removed
Entrepreneurial role models	E1	0.675	0.657	Retained
	E2	0.786	0.820	Retained
	E3	0.586	–	Removed
	E4	0.791	0.848	Retained
Outcome expectations	F2	−0.559	–	Removed
	F3	−0.407	–	Removed
	F4	0.870	1.000	Retained
Socio-structural facilitators	G1	0.506	0.790	Retained
	G2	0.642	0.861	Retained
	G5 (r)	−0.744	–	Removed
Entrepreneurial intention	H1	0.691	0.719	Retained
	H3	0.725	0.777	Retained
	H4	0.721	0.751	Retained
	H5	0.660	–	Removed

Note. Initial model contained all Likert-type items fielded; (r) = reverse-scored. Loadings below 0.708 are retained only where the construct met AVE and composite reliability criteria (Hair et al., 2022).

5.5.2 Internal consistency reliability and convergent validity

Table 7 summarises Cronbach's alpha, Dijkstra–Henseler's rho A, composite reliability, and AVE for the final measurement model. Composite reliability (**ρc**) ranged from 0.790 (social support) to 0.894 (entrepreneurial passion) for all multi-item constructs, within the 0.70 to 0.95 range. Cronbach's alpha exceeded 0.70 for entrepreneurial passion (0.851) and entrepreneurial self-efficacy (0.730). It fell between 0.6 and 0.70 for role models (0.674), entrepreneurial intention (0.610) and social support (0.605) and was 0.539 for socio-structural facilitators. Because Cronbach's alpha is a conservative lower bound that is sensitive to the number of items, Hair et al. (2022) recommended that it be read alongside **ρc** and **ρA**. On that basis, reliability was judged acceptable for the five-, four-, and three-item constructs, but the two-item socio-structural facilitators constructs showed weaker reliability, and this is treated as a limitation. All multi-item constructs met the convergent validity criterion, with AVE values from 0.554 (entrepreneurial self-efficacy) to 0.683 (socio-structural facilitators). The above findings serve to demonstrate the composite reliability and convergent validity of the measures used. The relatively lower alpha values are recognised as weaknesses.

Table 7 Internal consistency reliability and convergent validity

Construct	Cronbach's α	ρA	ρc (CR)	AVE
Entrepreneurial passion	0.851	0.855	0.894	0.627
Entrepreneurial self-efficacy	0.730	0.732	0.832	0.554
Social support	0.605	0.618	0.790	0.558
Entrepreneurial role models	0.674	0.704	0.821	0.608
Outcome expectations	–	–	–	–
Socio-structural facilitators	0.539	0.550	0.811	0.683
Entrepreneurial intention	0.610	0.610	0.793	0.561

Note. ρA = Dijkstra-Henseler reliability; ρc = composite reliability; AVE = average variance extracted. Reliability and AVE are not defined for the single-item outcome expectations construct. Thresholds: α and ρc 0.70–0.95; AVE ≥ 0.50 (Hair et al., 2022).

5.5.3 Discriminant validity

Discriminant validity was assessed with three criteria. Under the Fornell-Larcker criterion, Table 8 presents the Fornell–Larcker assessment, showing that the square root of the AVE of each construct exceeded its correlations with all other constructs, so the criterion was satisfied. The margin was narrow for entrepreneurial self-efficacy, whose square root AVE (0.744) only marginally exceeded its correlation with entrepreneurial passion (0.727). The cross-loadings (Appendix C) also supported discriminant validity, every indicator loaded more highly on its own construct than on any other construct.

Table 8 Fornell-Larcker criterion

	EP	ESE	SS	RM	OE	SF	EI
EP	0.792						
ESE	0.727	0.744					
SS	0.509	0.555	0.747				
RM	0.656	0.667	0.543	0.780			
OE	0.348	0.385	0.353	0.407	1.000		
SF	0.160	0.140	0.313	0.179	0.229	0.826	
EI	0.625	0.476	0.342	0.437	0.383	0.163	0.749

Note. Values on the diagonal are the square roots of the AVE; off-diagonal values are latent variable correlations. EP = entrepreneurial passion; ESE = entrepreneurial self-efficacy; SS = social support; RM = role models; OE = outcome expectations; SF = socio-structural facilitators; EI = entrepreneurial intention.

The Heterotrait-monotrait ratio (HTMT), which Henseler et al. (2015) show to be more sensitive than the Fornell-Larcker criterion, gave a less favourable picture. Table 9 presents the HTMT ratios alongside their bootstrapped 95% confidence intervals. Two aspects of these results need to be distinguished: the HTMT point estimate indicates whether a construct pair meets the specified threshold (0.85 as the conservative criterion, or 0.90 for conceptually similar constructs), whereas the confidence interval indicates whether discriminant validity can be established through the bootstrapped inference test. A point estimate below 0.85 therefore does not, by itself, establish discriminant validity if its confidence interval includes 1.

Sixteen of the 21 construct pairs met the conservative 0.85 threshold. Five pairs exceeded it: entrepreneurial self-efficacy and role models (0.946), entrepreneurial passion and entrepreneurial self-efficacy (0.916), social support and role models (0.889), entrepreneurial passion and entrepreneurial intention (0.862) and entrepreneurial passion and role models (0.861). In addition, the confidence interval for social support and entrepreneurial self-efficacy (HTMT = 0.834) included 1, despite its point estimate being below 0.85. Thus, six construct pairs had bootstrapped 95% confidence intervals that included 1: entrepreneurial self-efficacy and role models, entrepreneurial passion and entrepreneurial self-efficacy, social support and role models, entrepreneurial passion and entrepreneurial intention, entrepreneurial passion and role models, and social support and entrepreneurial self-efficacy. For these six pairs, the inference test did not establish discriminant validity. For the remaining pairs, the confidence intervals did not include 1, supporting discriminant validity under the inference test.

Table 9 Heterotrait-monotrait ratio (HTMT) with bootstrapped 95% confidence intervals

Construct pair	HTMT	95% CI	Assessment
ESE – EP	0.916	[0.769; 1.037]	Exceeds 0.90; CI includes 1
SS – EP	0.712	[0.510; 0.908]	Meets criterion
SS – ESE	0.834	[0.664; 1.029]	Meets 0.85; CI includes 1
RM – EP	0.861	[0.695; 1.007]	Exceeds 0.85; CI includes 1
RM – ESE	0.946	[0.803; 1.099]	Exceeds 0.90; CI includes 1
RM – SS	0.889	[0.701; 1.107]	Exceeds 0.85; CI includes 1
OE – EP	0.373	[0.181; 0.560]	Meets criterion
OE – ESE	0.448	[0.219; 0.664]	Meets criterion
OE – SS	0.461	[0.233; 0.699]	Meets criterion
OE – RM	0.502	[0.304; 0.708]	Meets criterion

Construct pair	HTMT	95% CI	Assessment
SF – EP	0.281	[0.156; 0.566]	Meets criterion
SF – ESE	0.225	[0.165; 0.569]	Meets criterion
SF – SS	0.522	[0.317; 0.863]	Meets criterion
SF – RM	0.290	[0.165; 0.635]	Meets criterion
SF – OE	0.303	[0.096; 0.566]	Meets criterion
EI – EP	0.862	[0.694; 1.028]	Exceeds 0.85; CI includes 1
EI – ESE	0.710	[0.495; 0.908]	Meets criterion
EI – SS	0.546	[0.364; 0.824]	Meets criterion
EI – RM	0.675	[0.444; 0.945]	Meets criterion
EI – OE	0.486	[0.268; 0.696]	Meets criterion
EI – SF	0.275	[0.165; 0.641]	Meets criterion

Note. Thresholds: 0.85 (conservative), 0.90 for conceptually similar constructs (Henseler et al., 2015). Percentile confidence intervals from 5,000 bootstrap subsamples.

In summary, the Fornell-Larcker criterion and the cross loadings supported discriminant validity, but the HTMT indicated substantial empirical overlap between entrepreneurial passion, entrepreneurial self-efficacy, role models and, to a lesser extent, social support and entrepreneurial intention. The HTMT point estimates and confidence intervals provide complementary evidence: some construct pairs exceeded the recommended point-estimate threshold, while the confidence intervals failed to establish discriminant validity for six pairs, including social support and entrepreneurial self-efficacy, whose point estimate was below 0.85.

The constructs were retained as separate because they are conceptually distinct in Social Cognitive Theory and the purified scales met the reliability and convergent validity criteria. The overlap is, however, material to the interpretation of the structural results and is taken into account in sections 5.7 and 5.12. This provision ensures that the results are not stated as conclusive, offering a clear foundation for the additional analysis discussed further in the chapter.

5.6 Common method bias and non-response bias

5.6.1 Common method bias

Two statistical tests for common method bias were applied, as specified in section 4.11.5 (Podsakoff et al. 2003). In Harman's single factor test, an unrotated principal component analysis of the 28 Likert-type items extracted seven components with eigenvalues above. The first component accounted for 29.8% of the total variance, below

the 50% threshold. In full collinearity assessment (Kock, 2015), each latent variable was regressed on all others. The resulting variance inflation factors in Table 10, which range from 1.139 to 2.969, indicate that common method bias did not pose a serious threat. Entrepreneurial passion (2.969), entrepreneurial self-efficacy (2.613) and role models (2.201) were, however, at or above the stricter value of 2.2 referred to in section 4.11.5. This again reflects the shared variance between these constructs identified in section 5.5.3 and reinforces the need for cautious interpretation of their unique structural effects.

Table 10 Collinearity statistics: inner VIF and full collinearity VIF

Construct	Inner VIF (predictors of EI)	Full collinearity VIF
Entrepreneurial passion	2.458	2.969
Entrepreneurial self-efficacy	2.742	2.613
Entrepreneurial role models	2.343	2.201
Outcome expectations	1.375	1.341
Socio-structural facilitators	1.224	1.139
Social support	1.871	1.714
Entrepreneurial intention	–	1.733
Age band (control)	1.205	–
Gender: female (control)	1.117	–
Family business background (control)	1.344	–
University-type institution (control)	1.231	–

Note. Inner VIF values refer to the predictors of entrepreneurial intention; full collinearity VIF values are computed among the seven latent variables (Kock, 2015). Threshold: 3.3.

5.6.2 Non-response bias

Non-response bias was assessed by comparing the first and last quartiles of respondents by submission time (n = 28 each), on the assumption that late respondents resemble non-respondents (Armstrong & Overton, 1977). The Mann-Whitney U test was used to study the differences between early respondents (first quartile) and late respondents (last quartile) for the estimate of potential non-response bias. The results point to differences between two groups between statistically significant in entrepreneurial self-efficacy (\(p = .016/)) and socio-structural facilitators (\(p = .010\)). Early respondents reported higher entrepreneurial self-efficacy (4.04) is higher than late respondents (3.53), while late respondents reported higher perceives socio-structural facilitators (3.62) as early respondents (2.96). Since both p values are below the threshold value of .05, the difference is statistically significant. These findings suggest that late respondents differed

from both of these constructions which suggest potential non-response bias. It is appropriate to interpret the results cautiously as the observed differences may limit the extent to which the sample represents the wider target population in the above's light.

Table 11 Collinearity statistics: inner VIF and full collinearity VIF

Construct	Early (first quartile)	Late (last quartile)	Mann–Whitney p
Entrepreneurial self-efficacy	4.04	3.53	.016
Socio-structural facilitators	2.96	3.62	.010

Change the table note from “ordered by survey submission time” to:

Note. n = 28 per group, ordered by survey submission time.

Reason for the changes: The narrative’s “p = 016” is missing the decimal point. The socio-structural facilitator mean should match the table value of 3.62, and the timing terminology should be consistent with the text describing survey submission time.

The results also reported in Table 12, which compares the first and last quartiles of respondents according to survey submission time. The two groups did not differ significantly on entrepreneurial intention (p = .508), social support (p = .246) or outcome expectations (p = .231). Late respondents did, however, report significantly lower entrepreneurial passion (3.76 against 4.36, p = .003), entrepreneurial self-efficacy (3.53 against 4.04, p = .016) and role model exposure (3.74 against 4.30, p = .003). They also perceived the socio-structural environment as more enabling (3.62 against 2.96, p = .010). Under the approach adopted in section 4.12, these differences mean the absence of non-response bias cannot be assumed for those constructs. The dependent variable was not affected. In Table 12, retain the existing values except ensure these rows read as follows:

Table 12 Comparison of early and late respondents (construct means)

Construct	Early (first quartile)	Late (last quartile)	Mann-Whitney p
Entrepreneurial passion	4.36	3.76	.003
Entrepreneurial self-efficacy	4.04	3.53	.016
Social support	4.01	3.70	.246
Entrepreneurial role models	4.30	3.74	.003
Outcome expectations	3.86	3.52	.231
Socio-structural facilitators	2.96	3.62	.010
Entrepreneurial intention	3.90	3.67	.508

Note. n = 28 per group, ordered by survey start time.

5.7 Assessment of the structural model

5.7.1 Collinearity

Collinearity among the predictors of entrepreneurial intention was assessed before the path coefficients were interpreted. The inner variance inflation factors (VIFs) were examined to determine whether collinearity posed a concern in the structural model. As reported in Section 5.6.1, all inner VIF values were below the threshold of 3.3 (Kock, 2015). The highest values were for entrepreneurial self-efficacy (2.742), entrepreneurial passion (2.458), and role models (2.343). Collinearity was therefore below the level at which path estimates would be considered problematic, although the overlap among these predictors suggests that their unique contributions should be interpreted with appropriate caution.

5.7.2 Path coefficients

The table 13 provides the results of hypothesis tests for the relationship between entrepreneurial passion (EP), entrepreneurial self-efficacy (ESE), role models (RM), outcome expectations (OE), socio-structural facilitators (SF), social support (SS) and entrepreneurial intention (EI). Results are evaluated on the basis of Path coefficients (β), standard errors (SE), t statistics, p values and bias corrected and accelerated (BCa) 95% confidence intervals. These findings indicate support for H1, H2 and H6, while H3, H5, H7 and H8 were not supported. Entrepreneurial passion has positive and statistical significant relationship containing entrepreneurial intention (β = 0.571, SE = 0.125, t = 4.576, p < .001, 95 % CI [0.324, 0.809]), which has supported H1. This suggests that higher entrepreneurial passion is linked to a stronger entrepreneurial intention. Entrepreneurial passion also had a positive and significant relationship with entrepreneurial self-efficacy (β = 0.727, SE = 0.055, t = 13.296, p < .001, 95% CI [0.576, 0.807]), supporting H2. This also indicates that people reporting higher entrepreneurial passion have more confidence in their ability to carry out business activities. Outcome expectations was also positive and significant with regard to entrepreneurial intention (β = 0.198, SE = 0.081, t = 2.441, p = .015, 95% CI [0.049, 0.368]), and supported H6. This conclusion shows that better expectations of business outcomes are related to a more determined attitude towards entrepreneurship.

On the contrary, the company's self-efficacy did not show statistically significant direct relationship with entrepreneurial intention (β = -0.003, SE = 0.130, t = -0.026, p = .979, 95% CI [−0.246, 0.263]). Therefore, H3 was not supported. The role models were also not significantly associated with entrepreneurial intention (β = -0.004, SE = 0.122, t =

-0.030, p = .976, 95 % CI [-0.253, 0.224]), which means H5 is not supported. Socio-structural facilitators (β = 0.034, p = .655, 95% CI [−0.128, 0.172]) and social support (β = 0.025, p = .805, 95% CI [−0.186, 0.209]) also had non-significant relations with entrepreneurial intention. This led to no support for H7 or H8. The confidence intervals for these non-significant paths include zero and will reinforce the conclusion that the data which are given in the given model do not provide sufficient evidence for a direct relationship.

Control variables have given mixed results. The older band did not have a significantly associated with entrepreneurial intention (β = 0.142, p = .076, 95% CI [−0.011, 0.309]). The female gender dimension in the category was non-significant (β = 0.000, p = .996, 95 % CI [-0.155, 0.145]). The University type control is also non-significant (β = 0.010, p = .906, 95% CI [−0.164, 0.175]). For the family business the coefficient was negative (β = 0.178) and the reported p-value 048 but the 95% confidence interval [−0.342, 0.012] contains zero. Although the p-value is below .05, the confidence interval includes zero; therefore, under the stated joint criterion that a path is significant only when p < .05 and the confidence interval excludes zero, the family-business control is classified as not statistically significant.

Overall entrepreneurial passion showed up as the strongest positive predictor of entrepreneurial intention under reported direct paths, while outcome expectations also showed a significant positive relationship. Entrepreneurial passion also was strongly connected with entrepreneurial self-efficacy. However, entrepreneurial self-efficacy, role models, socio-structural intermediaries and social support had not demonstrated any direct intrinsic link to entrepreneurial intention in the model. These findings should be understood as associations, not as proof of causation. Figure 1 also shows the structural models effects.

Table 13 Structural model results: direct effects

Hyp.	Path	β	SE	t	p	BCa 95% CI	Result
H1	EP → EI	0.571	0.125	4.576	< .001	[0.324; 0.809]	Supported
H2	EP → ESE	0.727	0.055	13.296	< .001	[0.576; 0.807]	Supported
H3	ESE → EI	−0.003	0.130	−0.026	.979	[−0.246; 0.263]	Not supported
H5	RM → EI	−0.004	0.122	−0.030	.976	[−0.253; 0.224]	Not supported
H6	OE → EI	0.198	0.081	2.441	.015	[0.049; 0.368]	Supported

Hyp.	Path	β	SE	t	p	BCa 95% CI	Result
H7	SF → EI	0.034	0.076	0.446	.655	[−0.128; 0.172]	Not supported
H8	SS → EI	0.025	0.101	0.247	.805	[−0.186; 0.209]	Not supported
Control	Age band → EI	0.142	0.080	1.772	.076	[−0.011; 0.309]	Not significant
Control	Female → EI	0.000	0.077	0.005	.996	[−0.155; 0.145]	Not significant
Control	Family business → EI	−0.178	0.090	−1.980	.048	[−0.342; 0.012]	Not significant
Control	University-type institution → EI	0.010	0.087	0.118	.906	[−0.164; 0.175]	Not significant

Note. β = standardised path coefficient; SE = bootstrapped standard error (5 000 subsamples); BCa = bias-corrected and accelerated. A path is significant where p < .05 and the CI excludes zero.

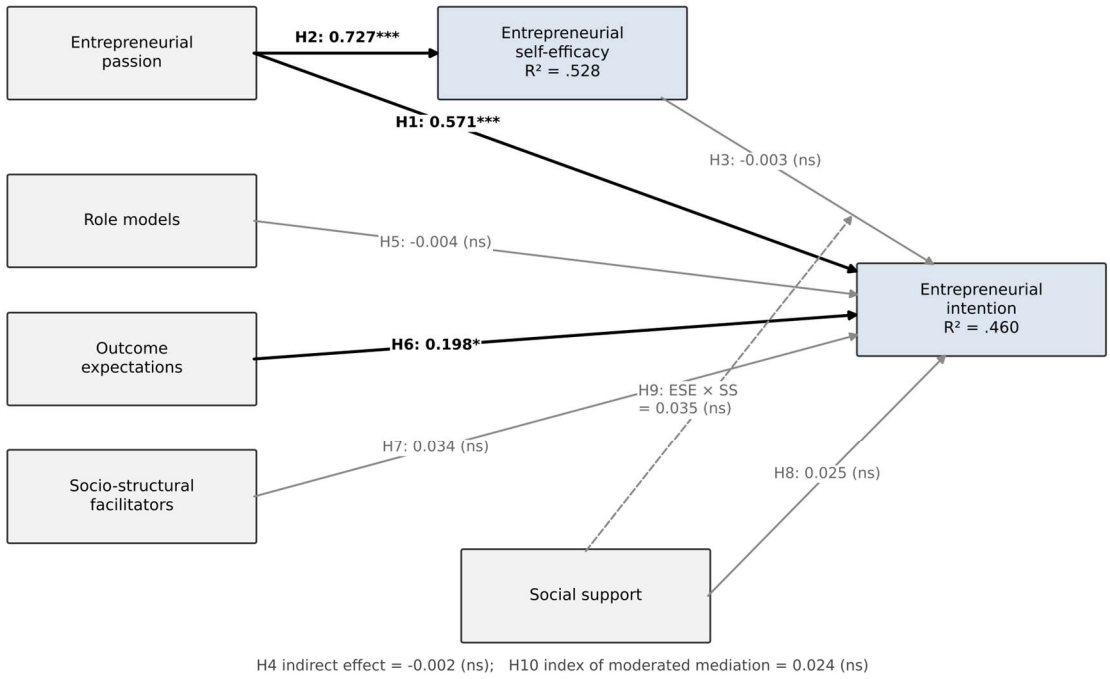


Figure 1 Estimated structural model

Note. Bold black arrows denote significant paths; grey arrows denote non-significant paths; the dashed arrow denotes the moderating effect of social support (SS) on the entrepreneurial self-efficacy (ESE) to intention path. *** p < .001; * p < .05; ns = not significant. Control variables are estimated but not shown.

5.7.3 Explanatory power, effect sizes and predictive relevance

The \(f^2\) effect sizes are reported in Table 14. Entrepreneurial passion had a medium effect on entrepreneurial intention (\(f^2 = 0.246\)) and a large effect on entrepreneurial self-efficacy (\(f^2 = 1.119\)). Outcome expectations had a small effect on intention (\(f^2 = 0.053\)), as did the age band (0.031) and family business (0.044) controls. Entrepreneurial self-efficacy, role models, socio-structural facilitators and social support had no measurable unique effect on entrepreneurial intention (\(f^2 \leq 0.002\)). Reason for the change: Table 5.13 reports \(f^2 = 0.002\) for socio-structural facilitators and \(f^2 = 0.001\) for social support. Therefore, "\(f^2 < 0.002\)" is not correct for all the listed predictors.

Table 14 Effect sizes (f^2) for predictors of entrepreneurial intention

Predictor	f^2	Effect size
Entrepreneurial passion	0.246	Medium
Entrepreneurial self-efficacy	0.000	No effect
Entrepreneurial role models	0.000	No effect
Outcome expectations	0.053	Small
Socio-structural facilitators	0.002	No effect
Social support	0.001	No effect
Age band	0.031	Small
Female	0.000	No effect
Family business	0.044	Small
University-type institution	0.000	No effect

Note. Thresholds: 0.02 small, 0.15 medium, 0.35 large (Hair et al., 2022). The f^2 of entrepreneurial passion on entrepreneurial self-efficacy was 1.119 (large).

Predictive relevance was assessed with blindfolding and the PLSpredict procedure (Hair et al., 2022), with an omission distance of seven; blindfolding gave Q^2 values of 0.272 for entrepreneurial self-efficacy and 0.182 for entrepreneurial intention. Both exceed zero, indicating predictive relevance. PLSpredict was run with ten folds and ten repetitions (Table 15). The Q^2 predict values for the three entrepreneurial intention indicators were all above zero (0.126 to 0.220). For two of the three indicators (H1 and H4), the root mean squared error (RMSE) of the PLS-SEM predictions was lower than that of the naïve linear regression benchmark, whereas for H3 the PLS-SEM RMSE was slightly higher. The mean absolute error (MAE) was also lower for PLS-SEM than for the linear regression benchmark for two indicators, but slightly higher for H3. These results provide evidence of predictive relevance and indicate mixed comparative predictive performance across the

three indicators. Therefore, the findings do not establish uniformly high out-of-sample predictive power; such a classification would require a more comprehensive assessment against the adopted methodological criteria (Shmueli et al., 2019).

Table 15 PLSpredict results for entrepreneurial intention indicators

Indicator	Q^2predict	RMSE (PLS-SEM)	RMSE (LM)	MAE (PLS-SEM)	MAE (LM)
H1	0.218	0.960	1.100	0.759	0.876
H3	0.220	1.004	1.018	0.812	0.805
H4	0.126	1.089	1.280	0.877	1.000

Note. 10-fold cross-validation with 10 repetitions. LM = linear regression benchmark using all exogenous indicators; RMSE = root mean squared error; MAE = mean absolute error.

5.8 Results for Research Question 1

Research Question 1 asked whether entrepreneurial passion and entrepreneurial self-efficacy exert direct effects on entrepreneurial intention among South African youth. It was tested through H1 and H3. The hypothesis-testing sections are explicitly linked to their corresponding research questions to ensure that the results address the study's stated objectives.

5.8.1 Hypothesis 1

H1: Entrepreneurial passion has a significant positive effect on entrepreneurial intention among South African youth.

Entrepreneurial passion had a significant positive effect on entrepreneurial intention (β = 0.571, t = 4.576, p < .001, 95% CI [0.324; 0.809]), with a medium effect size (f^2 = 0.246). It was the strongest predictor of entrepreneurial intention in the model. H1 was supported.

5.8.2 Hypothesis 3

H3: Entrepreneurial self-efficacy has a significant positive effect on entrepreneurial intention among South African youth.

With all other predictors and controls in the model, entrepreneurial self-efficacy had no significant effect on entrepreneurial intention (β = −0.003, t = 0.026, p = .979, 95% CI [−0.246; 0.263]; f^2 < 0.001). H3 was not supported. The bivariate correlation between the two latent variables was nevertheless positive and moderate (r = 0.476; Table 5.8). The

supplementary analysis in Section 5.12.1 reports the self-efficacy effect when entrepreneurial passion is excluded from the model.

5.9 Results for Research Question 2

Research Question 2 asked whether entrepreneurial self-efficacy mediates the relationship between entrepreneurial passion and entrepreneurial intention. It was tested through H2 and H4.

5.9.1 Hypothesis 2

H2: Entrepreneurial passion has a significant positive effect on entrepreneurial self-efficacy among South African youth.

Entrepreneurial passion had a strong, significant positive effect on entrepreneurial self-efficacy (β = 0.727, t = 13.296, p < .001, 95% CI [0.576; 0.807]). It explained 52.8% of the variance in self-efficacy, a large effect (f^2 = 1.119). H2 was supported.

5.9.2 Hypothesis 4

H4: Entrepreneurial self-efficacy mediates the relationship between entrepreneurial passion and entrepreneurial intention among South African youth.

Table 16 reports the mediation analysis and demonstrates that the indirect effect through entrepreneurial self-efficacy was not significant (β = −0.002, p = .980), whereas the direct effect remained significant and accounted for practically the whole total effect (β = 0.569, p < .001). The first stage of the mediated pathway (passion to self-efficacy) was strong, but the second stage (self-efficacy to intention) was not significant. Following the classification set out in Section 4.11.4 (Hair et al., 2022), the pattern is direct-only non-mediation. H4 was not supported.

Table 16 Mediation analysis: entrepreneurial passion, self-efficacy and intention

Effect	β	SE	t	p	BCa 95% CI
Total effect (EP → EI)	0.569	0.119	4.770	< .001	[0.334; 0.802]
Direct effect (EP → EI)	0.571	0.125	4.576	< .001	[0.324; 0.809]
Indirect effect (EP → ESE → EI)	−0.002	0.096	−0.025	.980	[−0.180; 0.201]

Note. Bootstrapping with 5,000 subsamples.

5.10 Results for Research Question 3

Research Question 3 asked whether entrepreneurial role models, outcome expectations and perceived socio-structural facilitators and impediments exert direct effects on entrepreneurial intention. It was tested through H5, H6 and H7.

5.10.1 Hypothesis 5

H5: Exposure to entrepreneurial role models has a significant positive effect on entrepreneurial intention among South African youth.

Role model exposure had no significant direct effect on entrepreneurial intention (β = −0.004, t = 0.030, p = .976, 95% CI [−0.253; 0.224]; $f^2 < 0.001$). Role models were, however, positively correlated with entrepreneurial intention (r = 0.437), entrepreneurial passion (r = 0.656) and entrepreneurial self-efficacy (r = 0.667). H5 was not supported.

5.10.2 Hypothesis 6

H6: Outcome expectations have a significant positive effect on entrepreneurial intention among South African youth.

Outcome expectations had a significant positive effect on entrepreneurial intention (β = 0.198, t = 2.441, p = .015, 95% CI [0.049; 0.368]), with a small effect size ($f^2 = 0.053$). The construct was measured by the single item F4 after F2 and F3 were removed (Section 5.5.1). The effect was robust across the alternative specifications in Section 5.12, including when the dichotomous financial outcome item F1 was added to the construct (β = 0.156). H6 was supported.

5.10.3 Hypothesis 7

H7: Perceived socio-structural facilitators have a significant positive effect on entrepreneurial intention among South African youth.

Perceived socio-structural facilitators had no significant effect on entrepreneurial intention (β = 0.034, t = 0.446, p = .655, 95% CI [−0.128; 0.172]; $f^2 = 0.002$). The construct also had the weakest bivariate correlation with entrepreneurial intention of all the predictors (r = 0.163). H7 was not supported.

5.11 Results for Research Question 4

Research Question 4 asked whether perceived social support moderates the relationship between entrepreneurial self-efficacy and entrepreneurial intention, and whether it conditions the indirect effect of entrepreneurial passion on intention through self-efficacy. It was tested through H8, H9 and H10.

5.11.1 Hypothesis 8

H8: Perceived social support has a significant positive direct effect on entrepreneurial intention among South African youth.

Social support had no significant direct effect on entrepreneurial intention in the main-effects model (β = 0.025, t = 0.247, p = .805, 95% CI [−0.186; 0.209]) or in the moderation model (β = 0.034, p = .734). The bivariate correlation with intention was positive (r =

0.342), and social support was moderately correlated with entrepreneurial self-efficacy (r = 0.555) and role models (r = 0.543). H8 was not supported.

5.11.2 Hypothesis 9

H9: Perceived social support moderates the relationship between entrepreneurial self-efficacy and entrepreneurial intention among South African youth, such that the relationship is stronger when social support is low.

The moderating effect was tested with the two-stage approach described in Section 4.11.4. Latent variable scores for entrepreneurial self-efficacy and social support were obtained from the main-effects model, and their standardised product was entered as an interaction term in the second stage. Table 17 presents the moderation results for H9, including the interaction coefficient and the conditional simple slopes.

The interaction term was small, positive and not significant (β = 0.035, t = 0.426, p = .670, 95% CI [−0.120; 0.207]). Adding it increased R^2 by only 0.001, an effect size of f^2 = 0.002. The positive sign is opposite to the negative interaction predicted by the compensatory hypothesis. The simple slope analysis (Figure 2) shows the relationship between entrepreneurial self-efficacy and entrepreneurial intention at low (−1 SD), mean and high (+1 SD) levels of social support. The slopes were −0.044, −0.011 and 0.023, respectively, and none differed significantly from zero. The lines in Figure 4 are close to flat and nearly parallel, so the self-efficacy to intention relationship was not stronger at low levels of social support. H9 was not supported.

Table 17 Moderation analysis: social support on the self-efficacy to intention path

Effect	β	SE	t	p	BCa 95% CI
ESE → EI (at mean SS)	−0.011	0.130	−0.082	.935	[−0.261; 0.254]
SS → EI	0.034	0.100	0.340	.734	[−0.171; 0.220]
ESE × SS → EI	0.035	0.082	0.426	.670	[−0.120; 0.207]
Simple slope at low SS (−1 SD)	−0.044	0.150	−0.292	.770	[−0.371; 0.226]
Simple slope at mean SS	−0.011	0.130	−0.082	.935	[−0.261; 0.254]
Simple slope at high SS (+1 SD)	0.023	0.154	0.148	.883	[−0.262; 0.334]

Note. Two-stage approach; the interaction term is the standardised product of the stage-one latent variable scores. Simple slopes are expressed per standard deviation of entrepreneurial self-efficacy. R^2 of the moderation model = 0.461.

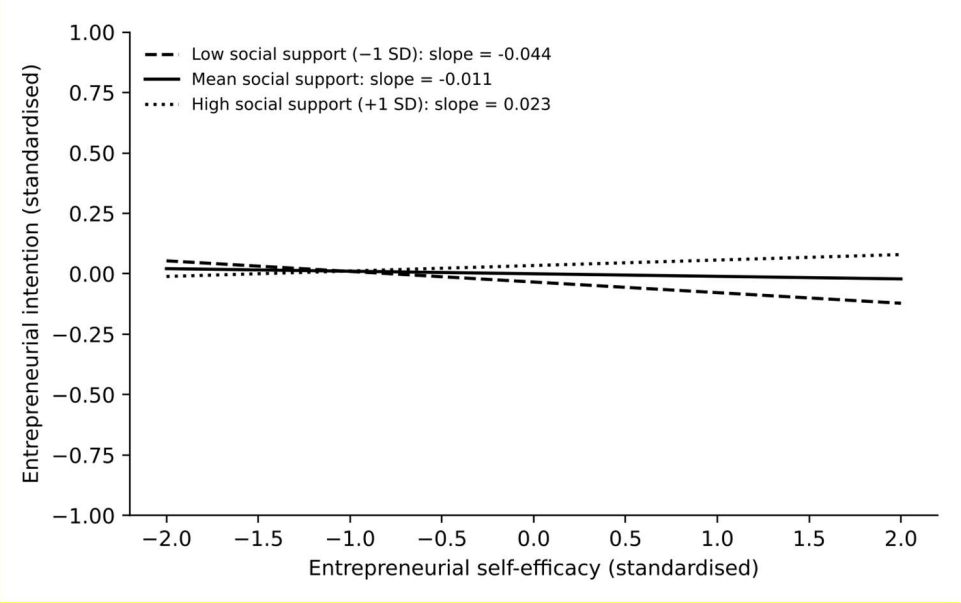


Figure 2 Simple slopes of entrepreneurial self-efficacy on intention at three levels of social support

Note. Lines are the estimated relationship between standardised entrepreneurial self-efficacy and entrepreneurial intention at one standard deviation below the mean, at the mean and one standard deviation above the mean of social support, holding other predictors at their means. None of the slopes is significant.

5.11.3 Hypothesis 10

H10: The indirect effect of entrepreneurial passion on entrepreneurial intention through entrepreneurial self-efficacy is moderated by perceived social support, such that the indirect effect is stronger when social support is low.

Table 18 reports the moderated mediation results for H10 and the conditional indirect effects of entrepreneurial passion on entrepreneurial intention through entrepreneurial self-efficacy at the three levels of social support, together with the index of moderated mediation (Hayes, 2022). The conditional indirect effects were −0.032 at low, −0.008 at mean and 0.016 at high social support, and all three confidence intervals included zero. The index of moderated mediation was 0.024 (t = 0.421, p = .674, 95% CI [−0.086; 0.144]), so the indirect effect did not vary significantly with social support. H10 was not supported.

Table 18 Moderated mediation analysis

Effect	β	SE	t	p	BCa 95% CI
Conditional indirect effect at low SS (−1 SD)	−0.032	0.112	−0.285	.776	[−0.274; 0.172]
Conditional indirect effect at mean SS	−0.008	0.097	−0.080	.936	[−0.195; 0.193]
Conditional indirect effect at high SS (+1 SD)	0.016	0.113	0.146	.884	[−0.191; 0.249]

Effect	β	SE	t	p	BCa 95% CI
Index of moderated mediation	0.024	0.057	0.421	.674	[−0.086; 0.144]

Note. Conditional indirect effect = a × (b + c·W), where a is the passion to self-efficacy path, b is the self-efficacy to intention path, and c is the interaction coefficient, evaluated at W = −1, 0 and +1 SD of social support.

5.12 Results for Research Question 5 and supplementary analyses

Research question 5 asked to what extent an integrated Social Cognitive Theory model accounts for variance in entrepreneurial intention. As mentioned in section 3.2, this is a model-level question answered by explanatory power and predictive relevance rather than by a single hypothesis. The integrated model explained 46% of the variance in entrepreneurial intention (adjusted R^2 = 0.408). It showed predictive relevance in blindfolding (Q^2 = 0.182) and high out-of-sample predictive power in PLSpredict (section 5.7.3). This explained variance came mainly from two of the six hypothesised determinants, entrepreneurial passion and outcome expectations. Their combined f^2 accounted for most of the model's explanatory power, while the remaining four determinants contributed no unique variance.

5.12.1 Supplementary analysis: the model without entrepreneurial passion

Because of the high collinearity and HTMT values between entrepreneurial passion and entrepreneurial self-efficacy (Sections 5.5.3 and 5.7.1), a supplementary model was estimated without entrepreneurial passion. This shows how the remaining determinants relate to intention when passion is not held constant. Table 19 presents the supplementary model estimated without entrepreneurial passion. In this model, entrepreneurial self-efficacy had a significant positive effect on entrepreneurial intention (β = 0.304, p = .019, 95% CI [0.034; 0.546]), as did outcome expectations (β = 0.209, p = .022). Role models (β = 0.143, p = .257), social support and socio-structural facilitators remained non-significant. Explained variance fell from 46.0% to 34.1%. The supplementary model is reported for transparency and does not replace the hypothesised specification. This complementary analysis offers further proof that the estimation of the entrepreneurial self-efficacy effect depends on the presence of entrepreneurial passion in the model. It is provided for disclosure purposes and does not substitute the originally hypothesised specification.

Table 19 Supplementary model excluding entrepreneurial passion: effects on entrepreneurial intention

Predictor	β	SE	p	95% CI
Entrepreneurial self-efficacy	0.304	0.129	.019	[0.034; 0.546]

Predictor	β	SE	p	95% CI
Entrepreneurial role models	0.143	0.126	.257	[−0.086; 0.404]
Outcome expectations	0.209	0.091	.022	[0.024; 0.375]
Socio-structural facilitators	0.032	0.082	.699	[−0.123; 0.200]
Social support	0.065	0.113	.563	[−0.150; 0.288]

Note. Controls included; percentile bootstrap confidence intervals (5,000 subsamples). $R^2 = 0.341$.

5.12.2 Robustness of the main results to measurement decisions

Several measurement decisions were required (section 5.4 and 5.5.1); the main model was re-estimated under six alternative specifications. Table 20 presents the robustness results across alternative measurement and model specifications. The two supported direct effects on intention, from entrepreneurial passion (0.453 to 0.573) and outcome expectations (0.156 to 0.217), kept their magnitude and sign in every specification that included passion. The passion to self-efficacy path was essentially unchanged (0.725 to 0.737). The self-efficacy, role model, social support and socio-structural facilitator paths stayed small (all $|\beta| \leq 0.12$) whenever passion was in the model. This included the original, unpurified item set, in which the self-efficacy coefficient was largest (0.119). The main results were therefore not an artefact of item purification, the treatment of the split items or the inclusion of controls.

Table 20 Robustness of path coefficients across alternative specifications

Specification	EP→ESE	EP→EI	ESE→EI	RM→EI	OE→EI	SF→EI	SS→EI	R^2 (EI)
Main model	0.727	0.571	−0.003	−0.004	0.198	0.034	0.025	0.460
Original full item set	0.737	0.453	0.119	0.066	0.217	0.016	0.009	0.509
EI incl. H5	0.725	0.508	0.035	0.059	0.175	−0.024	0.064	0.484
EI incl. H2 (binary)	0.726	0.573	0.039	−0.004	0.188	0.031	−0.072	0.456
OE incl. F1 (binary)	0.727	0.551	0.002	−0.007	0.156	0.038	0.033	0.447
No controls	0.727	0.566	0.006	−0.003	0.186	0.033	−0.026	0.422
EP removed	–	–	0.304	0.143	0.209	0.032	0.065	0.341

Note. Standardised point estimates. “Original full item set” uses all Likert-type items fielded, including those removed in Section 5.5.1. Binary items coded 1 = yes, 0 = no.

5.12.3 Exploratory comparison across entrepreneurial status

As mentioned in Section 4.11.6, comparison across the four strata was treated as exploratory. The strata overlapped in Section 5.2.2, and group sizes were small; a multi-group structural analysis was not feasible. Instead, mean entrepreneurial intention was compared between respondents who did and did not select each category. Table 21

reports the exploratory comparison of entrepreneurial intention across respondent categories. Respondents who owned or operated a business (M = 3.79), intended to start one (M = 3.86) or were enrolled in an entrepreneurship program (M = 3.83) reported intention levels similar to those who did not and the same held for family business background.

Table 21 Exploratory comparison of entrepreneurial intention across respondent categories

Category	n (yes)	M (yes)	n (no)	M (no)	Mann-Whitney p
Own/operate a business	68	3.79	46	3.85	.758
Intend to start within 24 months	76	3.86	38	3.72	.663
Enrolled in entrepreneurship programme	52	3.83	62	3.80	.634
Family business: Yes vs No/Maybe	56	3.86	58	3.76	.777

Note. Categories are not mutually exclusive. Intention is the mean of retained items H1, H3 and H4.

5.13 Summary of results

Table 5.22 consolidates the findings for all ten hypotheses and Research Question 5, allowing readers to identify the supported and unsupported relationships without searching through the individual results sections. Three of the ten hypotheses were supported. Entrepreneurial passion had a significant positive effect on both entrepreneurial intention (H1) and entrepreneurial self-efficacy (H2), and outcome expectations had a significant positive effect on entrepreneurial intention (H6). Entrepreneurial self-efficacy did not predict intention once passion was held constant (H3), so the hypothesised mediation was not observed (H4). Role models (H5), socio-structural facilitators (H7) and social support (H8) had no significant direct effects. Social support did not moderate the self-efficacy to intention relationship (H9) or the indirect effect of passion (H10). The integrated model explained 46% of the variance in entrepreneurial intention and showed predictive relevance (RQ5).

The findings indicate that entrepreneurial passion and outcome expectations were the principal supported predictors of entrepreneurial intention within the specified model. The measurement-model limitations, overlapping constructs, sample-size shortfall, and non-significant interaction effects are acknowledged to ensure that the results are presented transparently and without overstating their implications. The theoretical interpretation of these findings and their implications for entrepreneurship research and practice are developed in Chapter 6.

Table 22 Summary of hypothesis testing results

Hyp.	Relationship	RQ	Key statistic	Outcome
H1	Entrepreneurial passion → entrepreneurial intention (+)	RQ1	β = 0.571, p < .001	Supported
H2	Entrepreneurial passion → entrepreneurial self-efficacy (+)	RQ2	β = 0.727, p < .001	Supported
H3	Entrepreneurial self-efficacy → entrepreneurial intention (+)	RQ1	β = −0.003, p = .979	Not supported
H4	Self-efficacy mediates passion → intention	RQ2	Indirect = −0.002, p = .980	Not supported
H5	Role models → entrepreneurial intention (+)	RQ3	β = −0.004, p = .976	Not supported
H6	Outcome expectations → entrepreneurial intention (+)	RQ3	β = 0.198, p = .015	Supported
H7	Socio-structural facilitators → entrepreneurial intention (+)	RQ3	β = 0.034, p = .655	Not supported
H8	Social support → entrepreneurial intention (+)	RQ4	β = 0.025, p = .805	Not supported
H9	Social support moderates self-efficacy → intention (stronger when support is low)	RQ4	Interaction = 0.035, p = .670	Not supported
H10	Indirect effect stronger when support is low	RQ4	Index = 0.024, p = .674	Not supported
RQ5	Explanatory and predictive power of the integrated model	RQ5	R^2 = 0.460; Q^2 = 0.182	Weak to moderate explanatory power; predictive relevance established

CHAPTER 6: DISCUSSION OF RESULTS

6.1 Introduction

This chapter interprets the results presented in Chapter 5 in relation to the research questions and hypotheses developed in Chapter 3 and the literature reviewed in Chapter 2. No new results are introduced. The discussion is organised by research question, with each hypothesis considered in terms of whether the findings confirm, extend, or contradict previous research and what they imply for a Social Cognitive Theory (SCT) account of youth entrepreneurial intention in Gauteng, South Africa. Three features frame the

interpretation. First, the sample of 114 consisted predominantly of young people already engaged in entrepreneurship; most owned a business, intended to start one, or were enrolled in an entrepreneurship programmeme (Section 5.2.2). Second, several personal and environmental constructs were closely associated (Section 5.5.3). Third, the cross-sectional design supports conclusions about associations within the specified model, not causal sequence (Section 2.3.2). These features limit generalisation to young people with no prior entrepreneurial exposure and require the findings to be interpreted as evidence of unique associations rather than proof of causation.

6.2 Research Question 1: Direct effects of passion and self-efficacy on intention

6.2.1 Hypothesis 1: Entrepreneurial passion and entrepreneurial intention

H1 proposed that entrepreneurial passion would have a significant positive effect on entrepreneurial intention, and it was supported. Passion was the strongest determinant in the model and the only predictor with a medium effect size. This confirms the positive passion-intention relationship reported by Neneh (2020) among South African university students, by Al Halbusi et al. (2024) among Iraqi students and by Kyriakopoulos et al. (2024) in the United Kingdom and Greece, and it is consistent with the adolescent evidence of Porfírio et al. (2023). The present study extends this evidence to a Gauteng sample that was not confined to enrolled students and included young people who already owned or operated a business. No directly contradictory finding is identified among the studies cited here; however, the cultural explanations discussed below remain untested in this study.

The substantive implications of the finding are that intention to become an entrepreneur in this sample appears to have been driven not only by feasibility beliefs and anticipated outcomes but also by emotional commitment. The interpretation, however, needs to be understood in terms of the limitations of cross-sectional research design, where causation cannot be established.

The size of the effect also bears on the cultural contingency argument in Section 2.7.1. Kyriakopoulos et al. (2024) found that the passion–intention relationship differed in magnitude between national contexts and was stronger in Greece than they had expected. Alabduljader (2023) similarly showed that cultural context altered the relationships between cognitive antecedents and intention. The present finding that passion dominated all other determinants in Gauteng is consistent with the view that the weight of antecedents is not universal. It does not, however, test a cultural mechanism. As Section 2.7.1

cautioned, culture, Ubuntu or household obligations were not measured, so the strength of the passion effect cannot be attributed to them.

Two qualifications temper the interpretation. First, the passion and intention measures were empirically close (HTMT = 0.862). The passion items include identity-centred statements such as “Being involved in building a business is an important part of who I am”, which sit near the goal-intention items such as “My professional goal is to become an entrepreneur”. Section 2.2.1 drew on Ajzen’s (2020) compatibility principle to argue that an intention measure must identify the intended behaviour and not merge aspiration, favourable affect and commitment into one construct. Part of the passion–intention association may reflect this conceptual proximity rather than a purely antecedent relationship. Second, Section 2.4.1 positioned passion as an affective determinant within SCT rather than a construct Bandura operationalised. The finding therefore supports the extension of SCT-informed models to include affect, but it does not show that affect operates through the developmental sequence SCT describes, because practice over time was not observed (Neneh, 2020). It is for this reason that the magnitude of association should not be taken to mean that passion and intention are totally different constructs, with passion leading to intention.

6.2.2 Hypothesis 3: Entrepreneurial self-efficacy and entrepreneurial intention

H3 proposed that entrepreneurial self-efficacy would have a significant positive effect on entrepreneurial intention. It was not supported when passion and the other determinants were held constant. At face value, this contradicts one of the most consistent findings in the field. Krueger et al. (2000) identified perceived feasibility and self-efficacy as among the most powerful predictors of intention. Al-Qadasi et al. (2023), Ahmed (2022), Wardana et al. (2024) and Ho et al. (2025) all reported positive self-efficacy–intention relationships, and Edwards et al. (2022) linked the construct to behaviour as well as intention. Section 3.3.1 described self-efficacy as the most consistently powerful cognitive predictor and gave it the pivotal position in the hypothesised model.

The non-significant direct path does not mean that self-efficacy is unrelated to intention. It was positively correlated with intention and became a significant predictor when passion was excluded from the supplementary model (Table 5.18). This pattern suggests that the constructs capture overlapping aspects of entrepreneurial engagement: when passion is included, self-efficacy contributes little unique explanatory information. The finding therefore diverges from Krueger et al. (2000), Al-Qadasi et al. (2023), Ahmed

(2022), Wardana et al. (2024), and Ho et al. (2025), who reported positive self-efficacy–intention relationships, but it is consistent with Taneja et al. (2024), whose model found attitude more strongly associated with intention than self-efficacy. The present result qualifies rather than rejects the wider literature: among young people already engaged with entrepreneurship, perceived capability may accompany passion without independently explaining additional variation in intention. Two further explanations are consistent with the literature. Section 2.3.2 noted that a strong passion–self-efficacy association could reflect passion encouraging practice, confidence stimulating passion, or both being rooted in earlier experience. Where these constructs develop together through engagement, as Bandura's (2001) reciprocal account suggests, a cross-sectional model may be unable to separate their unique contributions. The second explanation concerns measurement. Section 2.4.2 argued that respondents confident in opportunity identification might be less confident in managing finances. The financial management item (C3) was the weakest self-efficacy indicator and was removed during purification, which supports the argument of Adebusuyi et al. (2022) that the task content of efficacy measures matters. A broader, multidimensional efficacy measure might discriminate more clearly from passion.

6.3 Research Question 2: The mediating role of entrepreneurial self-efficacy

6.3.1 Hypothesis 2: Entrepreneurial passion and entrepreneurial self-efficacy

H2 proposed that entrepreneurial passion would positively affect entrepreneurial self-efficacy, and it received the strongest support of all the hypotheses, with a large effect size. This converges with Neneh's (2020) finding that passion was positively associated with self-efficacy among South African students and with Bandura's (1977, 2001) account of affective and physiological states as sources of efficacy information. Adebusuyi et al. (2022) also supports the relevance of efficacy sources. No directly contradictory finding is identified among these cited studies, although the present cross-sectional design cannot establish the direction of the relationship.

From a theoretical point of view, the connection is plausible in light of the hypothesis that the emotional commitment to entrepreneurship and self-confidence in one's entrepreneurial skills might complement each other. In other words, passion could stimulate involvement in entrepreneurial activities, offering a chance to gain experience and become confident; meanwhile, feeling confident about one's own capabilities might fuel passion. Thus, the results found coincide with the reciprocal approach of Bandura (2001) and Adebusuyi et al. (2022), who provided empirical validation of sources of

efficacy being different antecedents. Nonetheless, neither the effect of passion on self-efficacy nor of self-efficacy on passion was proved by the conducted cross-sectional study. The strength of the relationship as well as the high HTMT between passion and self-efficacy implies that these constructs might have more of a personal resource relationship rather than sequential. Hence, the conclusion about the association can be drawn, whereas the relationship between passion and self-efficacy cannot be proven.

6.3.2 Hypothesis 4: Mediation through entrepreneurial self-efficacy

H4 proposed that self-efficacy would mediate the passion–intention relationship, with complementary partial mediation as the expected pattern (Section 3.3.2). It was not supported: although passion was strongly associated with self-efficacy, self-efficacy did not provide a significant second stage in the indirect pathway, so the result was classified as direct-only non-mediation. This contradicts Neneh's (2020) passion–self-efficacy–intention chain and the mediation structures reported for other antecedents by Taneja et al. (2024), Al Issa et al. (2025), Otache et al. (2022) and Duong (2023). The finding indicates that, in this sample, passion was associated with intention directly rather than through the proposed self-efficacy pathway. Section 2.4.3 noted that the mediation studies differed in constructs, outcomes and populations and could not be treated as interchangeable replications. It also cited the null mediation for situational factors in Al-Qadasi et al. (2023) as a limit on any universal claim that determinants reach intention through self-efficacy. Section 2.4.1 argued that the literature supported estimating direct and indirect paths separately rather than assuming passion mattered only through confidence. The present finding reinforces the importance of distinguishing a strong association between passion and self-efficacy from evidence that self-efficacy transmits the association between passion and intention. In this model, the proposed indirect pathway was not supported.

One interpretation is that among young people who already identify with entrepreneurial activity, commitment to venture creation is carried by affective identification itself, while capability beliefs develop alongside it rather than translating it into intention. A second is methodological. Because passion and self-efficacy overlap so heavily, the model has little independent variance with which to detect a mediated path, and a longitudinal design of the kind called for in Section 2.4.3 would be needed to examine the sequence directly.

6.4 Research Question 3: Role models, outcome expectations and socio-structural conditions

6.4.1 Hypothesis 5: Entrepreneurial role models

H5 proposed that exposure to entrepreneurial role models would have a significant positive effect on entrepreneurial intention. It was not supported. This differs from Al Halbusi et al. (2024), who found role models associated with e-entrepreneurial intention, and from the joint influence of role models and attitudes reported by Amofah and Saladrigues (2022). It closely matches the most relevant local evidence, however. Mothibi and Malebana (2025) found in Gauteng that role models were significantly related to perceived behavioural control, subjective norms and entrepreneurial behaviour but had no direct relationship with intention. Section 2.5.1 drew on this and on the review by Abbasianchavari and Moritz (2021) to argue that the direct role model–intention path was "a legitimate empirical question rather than an assured positive finding". The present study supports that position and replicates the local null in a sample that extends beyond university students. Based on the results obtained, one can conclude that there is no direct relationship between being exposed to role models of entrepreneurs and entrepreneurial intention. While it is possible that role models can be important when it comes to assessing one's ability and identifying oneself with entrepreneurship, this is not proven.

The finding should not be read as showing that role models are unimportant. Role model exposure was strongly correlated with self-efficacy (r = 0.667) and passion (r = 0.656). This pattern is consistent with Bandura's (1977) account of vicarious experience as a source of efficacy information and with the Mothibi and Malebana (2025) finding that role models operated through cognitive variables. Section 2.8.2 acknowledged that a direct role model path does not fully represent observational learning through self-efficacy.

The correlations between role model exposure and the personal determinants are also consistent with the hypothesis that the influence of role models is related to intention through, or together with, the personal determinants. Nevertheless, this current research did not test an indirect path where role model exposure influences intention via the personal determinants. The measurement of proximity also deserves comment. H5 rested on Bandura's (2001) similarity condition, but the item on access to role models in one's community (E3) was removed for a low loading, and the similar-background item (E1) was the weakest retained indicator. The proximity dimension, which Section 3.3.3 identified as central in the South African setting, was therefore captured only partially. In SCT, observational learning is more than mere exposure. People make meaning and evaluate what they have observed, and the resulting impact may be influenced by perceived

similarity, self-capability beliefs, and the relevance of the observed experience. The findings are therefore consistent with a possible indirect role for entrepreneurial role models, but this explanation remains tentative and warrants direct testing in future research.

6.4.2 Hypothesis 6: Outcome expectations

H6 proposed that outcome expectations would have a significant positive effect on entrepreneurial intention. It was supported, and the association remained stable across specifications, including the supplementary model without passion. This is the clearest confirmation of a distinct SCT element in the model. Bandura (1977) distinguished efficacy expectations from outcome expectations, arguing that believing a course of action will produce valued consequences differs from believing oneself capable of it. Weng et al. (2025) found that outcome expectations carried the effect of entrepreneurial practice on intention even when self-efficacy was considered as a competing mediator. Lam et al. (2025) and Adebusuyi et al. (2022) likewise treated the two as separate constructs. The present result, in which outcome expectations predicted intention independently of both passion and self-efficacy, supports that distinction in a South African youth sample. Young people may feel committed and capable yet still weigh whether the rewards justify the risks.

Theoretically, this finding reinforces SCT's distinction between efficacy expectations (beliefs about one's capability to act) and outcome expectations (beliefs about the consequences of acting). It converges with Bandura (1977), Weng et al. (2025), Lam et al. (2025), and Adebusuyi et al. (2022). Taneja et al. (2024) is not a direct contradiction because that study examined a general attitude construct rather than the same outcome-expectation measure; its comparatively stronger attitude association instead highlights the importance of distinguishing constructs.

The effect was considerably smaller than the attitude coefficient of 0.872 reported by Taneja et al. (2024). This is consistent with the argument in Section 2.4.4 that general favourable attitudes and specific outcome expectations are different constructs, and that coefficients from attitude-based studies cannot simply be carried over. The measurement experience reinforces that argument. The social (F2) and self-evaluative (F3) outcome items did not cohere with the material and risk–reward items and were removed, leaving the construct measured by a single risk–reward item (F4). The aim stated in Section 3.6 of examining material, social and self-evaluative outcome dimensions separately, could therefore not be realised. What remains is evidence that the anticipated balance of rewards against risks is associated with intention. This is consistent with the 84.1% of

respondents who expected business ownership to offer a better financial future than employment. Section 2.4.4 warned that outcome expectation measures require careful content validation, and the present study confirms that caution. The findings should therefore be interpreted as evidence concerning the anticipated balance between entrepreneurial rewards and risks, rather than as comprehensive evidence covering the financial, social, and self-evaluative dimensions originally intended.

6.4.3 Hypothesis 7: Socio-structural facilitators and impediments

H7 proposed that perceived socio-structural facilitators would have a significant positive effect on entrepreneurial intention. It was not supported. The finding is consistent with Mothibi et al. (2025), who found that financial support was not significantly associated with intention among Gauteng students, and with Mothibi et al. (2024), who found that environmental factors such as government policy did not have uniform associations among Gauteng SME owners. Kusumojanto et al. (2021) similarly found that environmental inputs related to intention differently and not always directly. The result does not support the expectation, drawn from Duong (2023) and Pham et al. (2024), that perceived barriers and environmental conditions predictably reach intention. Those studies modelled indirect paths through self-efficacy or education, however, which the present model did not specify for this construct. The results reveal a difference between intention to be an entrepreneur and perception of the environment as favourable to entrepreneurship. Individuals might have high levels of entrepreneurial intentions regardless of problems with finance and government support or business development programs. But the lack of a significant direct relationship does not mean that the structural constraints have no role to play.

The measurement results connect directly to the argument in Section 2.5.4 that facilitators and impediments cannot be assumed to be opposite ends of a single scale, because a respondent might perceive accessible advice and serious barriers at the same time. The reverse-scored impediment item (G5) loaded negatively once reversed: respondents who reported better access to funding and policy support did not report that the business environment was less difficult. This is consistent with Boucher et al. (2023), who found favourable views of entrepreneurship coexisting with fear of failure and ecosystem barriers in Nelson Mandela Bay. Perceived socio-structural conditions scored lowest of all constructs (M = 3.08), and only 38.6% of respondents reported that incubators and supplier development programmes were available to them. Read together, these results suggest that young people in this sample formed intentions largely independently of how they rated the institutional environment. The result should, however, be weighted

cautiously because the two-item construct had the weakest reliability in the model. Nevertheless, the two-item measurement of socio-structural conditions and the removal of the reverse-scored impediment indicator limit the breadth of the conclusions. Future studies should distinguish more clearly between perceived barriers, available resources, institutional support, and actual access to entrepreneurial opportunities.

6.5 Research Question 4: The direct and conditional role of social support

6.5.1 Hypothesis 8: Social support as a direct influence

H8 proposed that perceived social support would have a positive direct effect on entrepreneurial intention. The hypothesis was not supported, although social support was positively correlated with intention. This suggests that encouragement from family, friends, and other contacts may accompany entrepreneurial intention without contributing a distinct direct association once personal determinants are considered. One possibility is that support is associated with personal resources such as self-efficacy or passion; however, this pathway was not directly tested in the present model. This contradicts Neneh's (2020) positive direct relationship among South African students and Boucher et al.'s (2023) finding that family and peer support improved attitudes and intentions. It also does not support the proxy agency argument of Tornikoski et al. (2026), from which a substantial direct support effect would be expected in collectivist settings. Section 2.5.2 placed support as an environmental influence that could operate directly or through its relationship with personal cognition, and the observed correlations are consistent with the possibility of such a relationship, without demonstrating an indirect effect. Social support was correlated with self-efficacy (r = 0.555) and role models (r = 0.543), consistent with Bandura's (1977) treatment of verbal persuasion as a source of efficacy information. Once the personal determinants were controlled for, support had no unique association with intention. The measured support items also emphasised encouragement and access to advice (D1, D2, D4), the persuasion aspect that Section 2.5.2 distinguished from practical assistance that changes whether action is feasible. The community organisation item (D5), the closest to instrumental support, was removed for a low loading.

6.5.2 Hypothesis 9: Social support as a boundary condition

H9 proposed a compensatory moderation in which the self-efficacy–intention relationship would be stronger where social support was low. It was not supported. The interaction was small and non-significant, and the simple slopes at all three levels of support were close to zero. The study therefore did not replicate the compensatory pattern Neneh (2020) reported. It also gave no support to the complementary interpretation,

consistent with Ahmed (2022), in which support strengthens the effect of efficacy. The result resembles Pham et al. (2023), where several hypothesised moderation paths were not significant. Section 2.5.3 treated the compensatory expectation as “a proposition to be evaluated, not an established South African regularity”, and in this sample it was not borne out.

These findings indicate that social support did not operate as the hypothesised boundary condition in the present sample. The absence of a significant interaction does not establish that support has no practical value; rather, it indicates that the specified conditional relationships were not demonstrated by the available data. Three considerations help interpret this null result. First, because self-efficacy showed no unique association with intention in the main model, there was little relationship for support to condition. Second, as Section 4.14 anticipated, the sample of 114 was smaller than the planned 150–200, so the non-significant interaction may reflect either a genuinely absent effect or limited statistical power; it should not be treated as proof that moderation never occurs. Third, Neneh’s (2020) study focused on university students, whereas the present sample was largely already engaged with entrepreneurship. As Section 2.7.3 noted, confidence and support may function differently at different stages of the entrepreneurial process. These population and power considerations may help explain why the compensatory pattern was not replicated.

6.5.3 Hypothesis 10: Moderated mediation

H10 proposed that the indirect effect of passion on intention through self-efficacy would be stronger at low levels of support. It was not supported: the index of moderated mediation was 0.024 and not significant. This follows from the results for H4 and H9. Because the indirect effect was itself negligible and the second-stage moderation was absent, no conditional indirect effect could emerge. The specification followed Duong (2023), and Section 2.5.3 explained that the conditional indirect effect depended on both a strong passion–self-efficacy path and a support-dependent self-efficacy–intention path. Only the first was present. The test applied the index of moderated mediation as Hayes (2022) recommends, rather than inferring moderation from differences in conditional effects, so the conclusion that the indirect effect did not vary with support is methodologically sound. The power caveat discussed under H9 applies equally here.

6.6 Research Question 5: Explanatory power of the integrated model

Research Question 5 asked to what extent an integrated SCT model accounts for variance in entrepreneurial intention among South African youth. The model provides a

useful, though incomplete, account of intention formation within this sample. The model explained 46.0% of the variance in intention, with predictive relevance confirmed by blindfolding and PLSpredict. By the benchmarks applied in Chapter 4, this is weak-to-moderate explanatory power with good out-of-sample prediction. The integrated model is therefore a reasonable account of intention in this population. Its explanatory power, however, came almost entirely from the personal domain: passion and outcome expectations carried the explained variance, while role models, social support and socio-structural conditions added no unique explanation.

This pattern bears on the theoretical rationale for SCT in Chapters 1 and 2. Section 2.3.4 distinguished SCT from the Theory of Planned Behaviour (TPB): TPB explains intention through attitudes, subjective norms, and perceived behavioural control, whereas SCT places particular emphasis on self-efficacy, outcome expectations, reciprocal interactions between personal and environmental factors, and agency (Bandura, 2001). The present findings offer partial support for the usefulness of an SCT-informed account because outcome expectations contributed uniquely to intention and the supplementary model showed a role for self-efficacy when passion was excluded. However, the study did not estimate a competing TPB model, so it cannot establish that SCT explains intention better than TPB.

Within the specified direct-effects model, passion and outcome expectations explained intention more clearly than the environmental predictors. This does not establish that environmental conditions are generally unimportant. In Bandura's (2001) triadic account, environmental influences may shape personal cognition, and the associations of role models and social support with personal determinants are compatible with that possibility. Because the empirical model focused on direct environmental paths, indirect routes through efficacy and expectations remain possibilities for future testing rather than demonstrated mechanisms.

The supplementary model adds a further insight. When passion was excluded, self-efficacy and outcome expectations were both significant predictors. These are the two proximal determinants of choice in the social cognitive account set out in Section 2.3.3, as operationalised by Adebusuyi et al. (2022) and tested longitudinally by Belchior and Lyons (2021). The classical SCT structure is therefore visible in the data, but adding passion absorbs much of the self-efficacy contribution. The integrated model is thus best read as SCT's personal determinants extended by an affective component that dominates intention formation in this population. Finally, Tsou et al. (2023) found that intention

explained about 17% of behavioural variance. Even a well-explained intention leaves most of the eventual behaviour unexplained, a boundary Section 2.2.2 set on what the present findings can support. Overall, the findings contribute to entrepreneurship research by showing the value of extending an SCT-informed model to include entrepreneurial passion alongside self-efficacy and outcome expectations. They also illustrate the distinction between a construct's theoretical relevance and its unique statistical contribution when related predictors are included together.

6.7 Control variables and the research context

Collectively, the research results satisfy the research objectives through the determination of personal and environmental factors that predicted entrepreneurship intentions, assessment of mediating and moderating processes, as well as the explanatory capacity of the composite model. None of the control variables had a significant effect under the joint criterion, but two warrant brief comment. Family entrepreneurial background had a negative, borderline coefficient once the other determinants were controlled for, and mean intention did not differ between respondents with and without a family business background.

This is consistent with Amofah and Saladrigues (2022), who found that parental self-employment was not directly and significantly related to intention, and with Feldmann (2022), who argued that family influences may operate through norms and roles rather than simple exposure. The negative partial coefficient in the present study should be interpreted cautiously: it does not establish that family-business experience reduces intention, and the proposed explanation would require further evidence. Gender had no effect on intention. The study did not test the gender moderation of the intention–behaviour link reported by Silva et al. (2026) or the gender–culture interaction reported by Kyriakopoulos et al. (2024), so the null main effect does not speak to those findings. From a theoretical perspective, the results support the relevance of SCT while qualifying the assumption that its personal and environmental determinants will all demonstrate significant independent direct effects. The findings are most consistent with a model in which passion and outcome expectations contribute directly to intention, while other influences may operate through more complex relationships that require further investigation.

The context of the sample conditions all the findings above. Section 2.7.3 warned that a heterogeneous convenience sample is not automatically representative and that subgroup differences could reflect selection. The achieved sample was highly educated,

largely engaged with entrepreneurship and lacked respondents from the broader youth segment without entrepreneurial exposure. Early respondents also reported higher passion, self-efficacy and role model exposure than late respondents. The study therefore speaks most directly to young people already in, or close to, the entrepreneurial pipeline. This is a population of practical importance, since Zwane and Osuigwe (2024) studied programme participants with similar characteristics, but it is not the full youth population described in Section 4.5.

6.8 Summary of findings in relation to the literature

Table 23 summarises how each finding relates to the literature reviewed in Chapter 2, indicating whether it confirms, extends or contradicts the prior evidence. The findings converge with previous research on entrepreneurial passion and outcome expectations, while diverging from studies that report independent direct effects of self-efficacy, role models, and social support. These differences suggest that the influence of entrepreneurial determinants may depend on population characteristics, construct measurement, and the inclusion of closely related variables in the same model.

Table 23 Summary of findings in relation to the literature

Hypothesis	Result	Relationship to the literature
H1 Passion → intention	Supported	Confirms Neneh (2020), Al Halbusi et al. (2024), Kyriakopoulos et al. (2024); extends to engaged non-student youth in Gauteng, where passion is the dominant determinant
H2 Passion → self-efficacy	Supported	Confirms Neneh (2020); consistent with affective states as an efficacy source (Bandura, 1977; Adebusuyi et al., 2022)
H3 Self-efficacy → intention	Not supported	Contradicts Krueger et al. (2000), Al-Qadasi et al. (2023), Ahmed (2022) when passion is controlled; consistent with Taneja et al. (2024) that self-efficacy is not the strongest predictor in every specification
H4 Mediation	Not supported	Contradicts Neneh (2020), Taneja et al. (2024), Al Issa et al. (2025); consistent with Al-Qadasi et al. (2023) that not all influences operate through self-efficacy
H5 Role models → intention	Not supported	Consistent with Mothibi and Malebana (2025) and Abbasianchavari and Moritz (2021); contradicts Al Halbusi et al. (2024)
H6 Outcome expectations → intention	Supported	Confirms Bandura's (1977) efficacy–outcome distinction and Weng et al. (2025); smaller than attitude effects in Taneja et al. (2024)

Hypothesis	Result	Relationship to the literature
H7 Socio-structural facilitators → intention	Not supported	Consistent with Mothibi et al. (2024, 2025) and Kusumojanto et al. (2021); supports Section 2.5.4 that facilitators and impediments are not one continuum
H8 Social support → intention	Not supported	Contradicts Neneh (2020) and Boucher et al. (2023); the correlations are consistent with a possible association between support and personal cognition, although mediation was not tested
H9 Compensatory moderation	Not supported	Does not replicate Neneh (2020) or the amplifying pattern in Ahmed (2022); similar to non-significant moderation in Pham et al. (2023)
H10 Moderated mediation	Not supported	Duong (2023) structure not replicated; follows from H4 and H9
RQ5 Integrated model	$R^2 = 0.460$	Personal determinants carry the explanation; associations between environmental and personal factors are consistent with possible indirect relationships, which require further testing (Bandura, 2001); intention–behaviour gap remains (Tsou et al., 2023)

6.9 Conclusion

This chapter interpreted the results of Chapter 5 against the literature and hypotheses. The evidence supported three of the ten hypotheses and produced a coherent, if partly unexpected, picture of intention formation among engaged young people in Gauteng. Entrepreneurial passion was the dominant determinant: it related to intention directly and was strongly associated with self-efficacy. The key finding was that entrepreneurial passion and outcome expectations were the most strongly supported direct factors that influenced entrepreneurial intention for the sampled youths in Gauteng.

Outcome expectations made a distinct contribution, which confirms the SCT distinction between capability beliefs and anticipated consequences. Self-efficacy, role models, social support and perceived socio-structural conditions were all correlated with intention but added no unique explanation once passion and outcome expectations were included, and the hypothesised compensatory role of social support was not observed. These findings extend the passion and outcome expectation literature to a new population. They qualify the established primacy of self-efficacy, and the role-model and social-support correlations are consistent with the possibility that some environmental influences may be associated with personal determinants rather than having independent direct associations with intention. However, the study did not establish these indirect pathways.

The findings do not replicate the compensatory support mechanism. Chapter 7 draws these findings together into conclusions, sets out their implications for theory and practice, and identifies the limitations of the study and directions for future research. Special consideration needs to be paid to the areas of longitudinal studies, more refined measurement of entrepreneurial passion and self-efficacy, greater participation of youths at various stages of exposure to entrepreneurship, and exploration of mechanisms whereby social and structural factors might impact on entrepreneurial development.

CHAPTER 7: CONCLUSIONS AND RECOMMENDATIONS

7.1 Introduction

This chapter concludes the research report. Following the structure prescribed for the concluding chapter, it sets out what was studied and why it matters, the research context, the state of prior knowledge, the questions answered and the methodology used. It then presents the principal findings and their interpretation, the contribution to scholarly debate, the practical and business relevance of the findings, the limitations of the study and recommendations for future research.

7.2 What was studied and why it matters

The study investigated the personal cognitive and environmental determinants of entrepreneurial intention among young South Africans aged 18 to 35 in Gauteng, using Social Cognitive Theory (SCT) as the explanatory framework (Bandura, 2001). Its starting point was an empirical paradox. South Africa combines some of the highest youth unemployment rates in the world with low and declining entrepreneurial intention, which shows that necessity has not translated into intention (Global Entrepreneurship Monitor, n.d.; Statistics South Africa, 2024, 2025). Because intention is the most reliable proximal predictor of venture creation (Krueger et al., 2000), understanding how it forms is a precondition for designing interventions that can raise entrepreneurial activity among young people. Public and private resources for youth enterprise development are currently allocated without reliable evidence on whether the binding constraint on intention is cognitive, environmental or the interaction between them. The study sought to provide that evidence.

7.3 The research context

Gauteng is South Africa's economic centre and contains the widest range of youth entrepreneurial settings, from metropolitan business districts to township and peri-urban informal economies. The national youth enterprise development system spans government agencies, development finance institutions, corporate enterprise and supplier

development programmes, higher education entrepreneurship centres and non-governmental incubators. Most of these programmes rest on the assumption that removing structural barriers such as access to finance, markets and skills will raise entrepreneurial activity. The context matters theoretically because the dominant intention models were developed and validated in Western and Asian settings. The extent to which their determinants carry the same weight in a setting shaped by structural inequality, collectivist social obligations and a large informal economy had not been established (Boucher et al., 2023; Canestrino et al., 2020; Shayo, 2023).

7.4 What was already known and not known

The literature established that entrepreneurial passion (Al Halbusi et al., 2024; Neneh, 2020), entrepreneurial self-efficacy (Al-Qadasi et al., 2023; Krueger et al., 2000) and anticipated outcomes (Adebusuyi et al., 2022; Weng et al., 2025) are associated with entrepreneurial intention. It also showed that self-efficacy can mediate the effects of affective and experiential antecedents (Neneh, 2020; Taneja et al., 2024). Environmental influences were found to be differentiated: role models, interpersonal support and institutional conditions did not have uniform effects (Abbasianchavari & Moritz, 2021; Mothibi et al., 2024, 2025). Three gaps remained. First, personal and environmental determinants had rarely been modelled together within a single SCT framework in South Africa (Kusumojanto et al., 2021). Second, the evidence was dominated by student samples, so its transfer to the broader youth population was uncertain. Third, the compensatory moderation by social support reported by Neneh (2020) rested on a single South African student sample and had not been tested in a broader population.

7.5 The research questions answered

The study addressed five research questions:

- RQ1: Do entrepreneurial passion and entrepreneurial self-efficacy exert direct effects on entrepreneurial intention among South African youth?
- RQ2: Does entrepreneurial self-efficacy mediate the relationship between entrepreneurial passion and entrepreneurial intention?
- RQ3: Do entrepreneurial role models, outcome expectations, and perceived socio-structural facilitators and impediments exert direct effects on entrepreneurial intention?

- RQ4: Does perceived social support moderate the relationship between entrepreneurial self-efficacy and entrepreneurial intention, and does it condition the indirect effect of passion on intention through self-efficacy?
- RQ5: To what extent does an integrated SCT model account for variance in entrepreneurial intention among South African youth?

The first four questions were tested through ten hypotheses (H1 to H10), and the fifth through the explanatory power and predictive relevance of the model as a whole.

7.6 How the questions were answered

The study adopted a positivist philosophy and a deductive, mono-method quantitative design. Data were collected through a cross-sectional, self-administered questionnaire distributed online and in person between August and October 2026 through higher education institutions, incubators, entrepreneurship networks and youth community organisations, using a non-probability, multi-frame sampling approach. After screening for age, residence and data quality, 114 valid responses were analysed. The data were analysed with partial least squares structural equation modelling (Hair et al., 2022). The reflective measurement model was assessed for reliability and validity, and the structural model was evaluated with bootstrapping (5 000 subsamples), mediation analysis, a two-stage interaction approach and the index of moderated mediation (Hayes, 2022). Common method bias, non-response bias and the robustness of results to measurement decisions were also assessed.

7.7 Principal findings and their interpretation

7.7.1 Conclusion on Research Question 1

Entrepreneurial passion had a strong, direct positive effect on entrepreneurial intention and was the dominant determinant in the model (H1 supported). Entrepreneurial self-efficacy was positively correlated with intention but had no unique effect once passion was controlled for (H3 not supported). The study concludes that among engaged young people in Gauteng, affective identification with entrepreneurship is the primary personal driver of intention. Capability beliefs accompany that identification but add little explanatory power beyond it. This qualifies, rather than overturns, the established view of self-efficacy as a leading predictor (Krueger et al., 2000; Taneja et al., 2024). This conclusion applies to the specified model and the study sample; it does not establish that passion is universally more important than self-efficacy across other populations or research settings.

7.7.2 Conclusion on Research Question 2

Passion was strongly associated with self-efficacy (H2 supported), but self-efficacy did not mediate the passion–intention relationship (H4 not supported). The pattern was direct-only non-mediation. The study concludes that the passion–self-efficacy–intention chain reported among South African students (Neneh, 2020) was not supported in the present sample of young people already engaged with entrepreneurship. Passion and self-efficacy behave as closely intertwined resources, and the proposed indirect relationship between passion and intention through self-efficacy was not demonstrated. Given the cross-sectional design and the observed overlap between the constructs, the findings do not establish that mediation is absent in all populations or that passion necessarily precedes self-efficacy.

7.7.3 Conclusion on Research Question 3

Outcome expectations had a significant positive effect on intention (H6 supported), confirming that anticipated rewards relative to risks matter independently of commitment and confidence (Bandura, 1977; Weng et al., 2025). Role models (H5) and perceived socio-structural facilitators (H7) had no direct effects. The study concludes that what young people expect entrepreneurship to deliver shapes their intention. Role models and institutional conditions do not act on intention. Role models were associated with passion and self-efficacy, which is in line with the suggestion that role models may have an effect on the intention through personal determinants. It should be noted, however, that the research could not test this indirect effect, and hence, it could not confirm whether intention is influenced by vicarious processes and other personal determinants (Mothibi & Malebana, 2025).

7.7.4 Conclusion on Research Question 4

Social support had no direct effect on intention (H8 not supported) and did not moderate either the self-efficacy–intention relationship (H9 not supported) or the indirect effect of passion (H10 not supported). The study concludes that the compensatory role of social support proposed by Neneh (2020) was not observed in this population. Support was associated with self-efficacy and role model exposure, which is consistent with a possible relationship between social support and personal cognition, although this study did not establish that support operates through these factors. Given the sample size, the moderation results should be regarded as inconclusive rather than as definitive evidence of no effect.

7.7.5 Conclusion on Research Question 5

The integrated model explained 46.0% of the variance in entrepreneurial intention and demonstrated predictive relevance. The study concludes that an SCT-informed model gives a reasonable account of youth entrepreneurial intention in Gauteng, but one carried by personal rather than environmental determinants. Within the specified model, passion and outcome expectations provided the clearest unique direct contributions to intention, whereas the environmental predictors did not add significant unique direct effects. The observed associations between environmental factors and personal determinants are consistent with the possibility of more complex relationships, but indirect environmental pathways were not tested. The theoretically expected structure of self-efficacy and outcome expectations as proximal determinants was visible when passion was excluded from the model.

7.8 Contribution to the scholarly debate

The current study adds to the existing literature on youth entrepreneurial intention by looking at personal and environmental factors simultaneously within the Social Cognitive Theory framework, in the case of the Gauteng region of South Africa. While its contribution is not in challenging the existing theories on entrepreneurial intention, it helps refine the relative importance of these explanations among a population mainly involved in entrepreneurship. The study makes five contributions to the literature.

Affect as the dominant determinant. The study adds to the evidence that the relative weight of intention antecedents is context-dependent (Alabduljader, 2023; Kyriakopoulos et al., 2024). In an SCT-informed model estimated in Gauteng, entrepreneurial passion was the strongest direct determinant of intention and the only predictor with a medium-sized effect. This supports the inclusion of affective components in SCT-based intention models and qualifies the assumption, common in the literature reviewed in Section 3.3.1, that self-efficacy will necessarily be the pivotal predictor in every population. The result does not establish that passion universally displaces self-efficacy; rather, it indicates that their relative explanatory contributions may vary by context and by the other constructs included in the model.

The limits of self-efficacy mediation. By showing direct-only non-mediation in a non-student sample, the study adds a context-specific qualification to the mediation findings of Neneh (2020), Taneja et al. (2024) and Al Issa et al. (2025). It adds weight to the cautionary evidence of Al-Qadasi et al. (2023) that not all antecedents reach intention through self-efficacy. The strong overlap between passion and self-efficacy in the present

sample may help explain why self-efficacy did not make a distinct contribution to intention once passion was included. However, the cross-sectional design and the absence of a significant indirect effect do not establish that mediation is inherently unimportant among young people already engaged with entrepreneurship. The findings instead highlight the need to examine the distinctiveness and temporal relationship of these constructs in future research.

Outcome expectations as distinct from attitude. The study operationalised outcome expectations as consequences of action rather than as a general attitude, and found them to predict intention independently of passion and self-efficacy. This supports the SCT distinction between efficacy and outcome expectations (Bandura, 1977) and the measurement argument of Adebusuyi et al. (2022). Because the social and self-evaluative items did not cohere, it also shows that the multidimensional outcome expectation construct requires further measurement development before it can be used with confidence in this context. This contribution is relevant to broader debates about construct specification in entrepreneurial intention research: anticipated consequences should not automatically be treated as interchangeable with general attitudes towards entrepreneurship.

Environmental determinants as indirect influences. The study replicates in a broader Gauteng sample the local finding that role models do not relate directly to intention (Mothibi & Malebana, 2025) and the finding that perceived financial and institutional conditions do not predict intention (Mothibi et al., 2025). It also provides empirical support for the argument that perceived facilitators and impediments are not opposite poles of a single continuum (Boucher et al., 2023; Kusumojanto et al., 2021). These results are based on the direct relationships that have been defined and tested within the current model. Even though role models and social support were found to be correlated with personal factors, these correlations do not prove that environmental factors affect intention indirectly. This study, thus, provides some paths for further research.

A test of compensatory support beyond students. The study offers the first test, to the researcher's knowledge, of Neneh's (2020) compensatory moderation outside a student sample in South Africa. It found no moderation in either direction. The finding is not proof of the proposed compensatory or amplifying relationship in this sample, but it should not be taken to mean that there is no evidence for such relationships at all. This is an important boundary condition for the proxy agency and compensatory accounts of social support (Tornikoski et al., 2026), although the result is constrained by statistical power.

Together, these contributions address three issues. First, they point out the necessity for models of entrepreneurial intention based on SCT to include not only efficacy beliefs and outcome expectations but also affective elements such as passion. Second, they show the need for the treatment of the significance of antecedents of intention as a function of context since findings in one population do not necessarily apply to another. Finally, the similarity between passion and self-efficacy calls into question the distinctiveness of the two constructs as contributing factors. This study is not about proving that SCT is superior to the Theory of Planned Behaviour (TPB). It compares two aspects of SCT rather than comparing SCT with TPB. More specifically, the study refines the understanding of how selected SCT-related determinants performed within one integrated model and one context. It does not demonstrate a general limitation of SCT or establish the superiority of one theoretical framework over another. Overall, the study contributes a context-specific refinement of SCT-informed entrepreneurship research: entrepreneurial passion and outcome expectations were the most clearly supported direct determinants of intention in this sample, while the unique contributions of several other constructs were limited.

7.9 Practical and business relevance

The findings carry implications for the stakeholders identified in Chapter 1. Because the study measured intention and not behaviour, the recommendations table 24 below focus on factors associated with entrepreneurial intention rather than claiming that particular interventions will lead to business creation or survival. The recommendations should therefore be treated as evidence-informed directions for practice that require evaluation, rather than as proven intervention effects.

Table 24 Recommendations for practice

Finding	Stakeholder	Recommended action	Suggested indicator for evaluation
Entrepreneurial passion was the strongest direct determinant of intention, but its strong overlap with	Youth enterprise development agencies and policymakers	Include opportunities for young people to explore entrepreneurial interests, values and personal fit alongside information about venture	Changes in entrepreneurial passion and intention, assessed separately using

self-efficacy and intention measures warrants caution.		development. Avoid assuming that passion alone is sufficient or that increasing passion will necessarily produce stronger intentions or successful ventures.	appropriately validated measures.
Outcome expectations were positively associated with intention independently of passion and self-efficacy. The retained measure mainly captured the perceived balance between rewards and risks.	Youth enterprise development agencies, policymakers and entrepreneurship programme providers	Provide accessible information and structured activities that help young people assess potential rewards, risks and trade-offs in entrepreneurship. Ensure that expectations are based on the opportunities and constraints relevant to the ventures being considered.	Changes in participants' outcome expectations and their ability to identify relevant entrepreneurial rewards and risks.
Role models had no significant unique direct association with intention, although role model exposure was correlated with passion and self-efficacy.	Corporate enterprise and supplier development programmes and mentorship providers	Structure mentorship around opportunities to learn from entrepreneurs, discuss business decisions and reflect on entrepreneurial tasks. Evaluate mentorship against learning, passion and self-efficacy outcomes rather than assuming that exposure alone will increase intention.	Participation in mentorship, perceived learning from role models, and changes in passion and self-efficacy.

Perceived socio-structural facilitators had no significant unique direct association with intention, and only 38.6% of respondents reported that incubators and supplier development programmes were available to them.	Youth enterprise development agencies, incubators and programme administrators	Review how information about existing incubators and supplier development programmes is communicated and how young people access them. Distinguish awareness, perceived availability and actual access when evaluating programme reach.	Awareness of programmes, applications, eligibility, enrolment and reported access among intended beneficiaries.
Self-efficacy did not make a significant unique direct contribution to intention when passion and the other determinants were included. The proposed compensatory moderation by social support was not supported.	Entrepreneurship educators and programme designers	Combine practical entrepreneurial tasks and opportunities to develop capability beliefs with reflection on motivation and expected consequences. Do not assume that confidence-building will have a greater effect on intention among young people with low social support; evaluate outcomes across different support levels.	Changes in self-efficacy, passion and outcome expectations, with results examined across levels of perceived social support.
Passion and self-efficacy were strongly associated, and the study measured intention rather than subsequent	Researchers and programme evaluators	Assess passion and self-efficacy as distinct constructs and, where feasible, follow participants over time to examine whether changes in these constructs	Evidence of construct distinctiveness and longitudinal changes in intention and

entrepreneurial behaviour.

correspond to changes in entrepreneurial intention and subsequent behaviour. entrepreneurial action.

7.9.2 Youth enterprise development agencies and policymakers

For youths looking into entrepreneurship, this means that the need to reflect on the reasons behind this move as well as the expected outcome of the entrepreneurial activities is highly recommended. Reflection, in this case, means examining the reasons for engaging in the business, what will be gained from the venture, what risks or limitations can arise, and other pertinent information needed to make an informed decision. This follows from the research finding that passion and outcome expectation were correlated with intentions, but it was not determined whether such reflection activities could increase intention or success of venture.

To policymakers and youth enterprise development agencies, the results mean that personal motivation can be considered along with existing structural support to youth in the entrepreneurial process. Agencies can include motivational activities in the provision of finance, access to markets, and skills training. Such motivational activities must be examined for effectiveness and cannot simply be assumed to work. The research does not prove whether increased enterprise support has resulted in increasing or decreasing intention. The low perceived availability of incubators and supplier development programmes (38.6%) also points to an awareness and access problem that outreach could address. The agencies could consider whether eligible youth are aware of existing programmes, understand how to apply for such programmes, and can actually utilise the services. The evaluation should separate awareness of a programme from the other stages of eligibility, enrolment and use of the programme. The evaluation would not just focus on awareness alone.

7.9.3 Entrepreneurship programme designers and educators

These suggestions for entrepreneurship education need to be taken as practical considerations for evaluation purposes, but not as intervention effects of this research effort. The research involved a cross-sectional methodology where a sample of 114 respondents was evaluated, who were already well-engaged with entrepreneurship activities. Furthermore, it assessed entrepreneurial intentions but not business creation or entrepreneurship results. The research findings have uncovered some links which can

assist in designing educational programs, but do not provide evidence that these activities would affect entrepreneurial intention or results. Educational institutions and entrepreneurship programme providers should integrate experiential learning with realistic evaluation of entrepreneurial opportunities. Passion was the strongest determinant of intention and was strongly associated with self-efficacy, so programmes could provide opportunities for participants to explore their interests and engagement with entrepreneurial work while developing practical skills. Examples include experiential projects, customer discovery, venture building in teams and reflection on personal purpose, alongside technical business content. Since self-efficacy did not contribute uniquely to intention once passion was controlled for, these results suggest that one should not assume that transferring skills and boosting confidence will automatically improve intention. This is not to say that such measures are ineffective; rather, this study did not test their effects.

The independent effect of outcome expectations indicates that programmes should help participants form realistic, evidence-based expectations of the financial and personal rewards of entrepreneurship relative to its risks. Realistic financial modelling, exposure to the actual earnings trajectories of young entrepreneurs and frank discussion of risk management are suitable ways to do this. Programme providers could determine if these interventions help participants become more aware of their perceived gains and risks in this respect, understanding that the maintained measure of outcome expectancy in this study is an indicator primarily of risk/reward balance rather than of all dimensions of outcome expectation.

7.9.3 Corporate enterprise and supplier development and mentorship programmes

Corporate enterprise and supplier development initiatives should treat mentorship as a structured learning opportunity rather than assuming that exposure to successful entrepreneurs will automatically increase intention. Role model exposure did not relate directly to intention but was closely associated with passion and self-efficacy. Mentorship and role model components should therefore be designed as ways of building engagement and capability, and evaluated against those outcomes, rather than expected to raise intention directly. The weakness of the community-access and similar-background items suggests that many young people lack proximate role models. Corporate enterprise development programmes could address this by featuring entrepreneurs whose starting circumstances resemble those of participants, in line with the similarity condition of vicarious learning (Bandura, 2001). This is an intervention that is theoretically-based

rather than proven, and future evaluative efforts need to measure whether people learn from these mentors and the impact this has on their passion, self-efficacy or intention.

7.9.4 Targeting of interventions

Practitioners should not assume that confidence-building interventions will be more effective for young people reporting low social support. The compensatory moderation by social support was not observed, so the study does not provide grounds for targeting self-efficacy interventions specifically at young people with weak social support, as Chapter 1 had anticipated. Until stronger evidence is available, practitioners should not assume that confidence-building delivers a greater marginal return for less supported youth. The findings instead suggest that passion and outcome expectations are the more promising targets across support levels. The fact is that sample size was smaller than that projected for this study, and there were no statistically significant interaction effects. The results are hence not conclusive proof that the intervention does not vary in its effectiveness dependent on social support.

7.10 Limitations of the research

The findings should be read in light of the following limitations.

- **Sample size and composition.** The analytic sample of 114 was below the planned 150 and the 500 stated in the ethics application. This limited statistical power, especially for the interaction effects in H9 and H10, and precluded multi-group analysis. The sample was highly educated and largely engaged with entrepreneurship, and the broader youth segment without entrepreneurial exposure was not separately represented, so the findings cannot be generalised to all young people in Gauteng.
- **Non-probability sampling and non-response bias.** The convenience and purposive sampling, together with significant differences between early and late respondents on passion, self-efficacy, role models and socio-structural perceptions, indicate possible self-selection of more entrepreneurially oriented respondents.
- **Deviations from the approved instrument.** Two items were omitted, four items were fielded with dichotomous response options, and the stratum item permitted multiple responses. As a result, outcome expectations were measured by a single item, socio-structural facilitators by two items with weak reliability, and the four strata could not be cleanly distinguished.

- **Discriminant validity.** HTMT values indicated substantial overlap between passion, self-efficacy, role models and social support. This limits the confidence with which the unique effects of these constructs can be separated and may partly explain the null results for self-efficacy, role models and support.
- **Cross-sectional, self-reported design.** All data were self-reported at one point in time. Temporal or causal order cannot be established; the reciprocal dynamics central to SCT could not be observed, and common method variance cannot be fully excluded despite the favourable statistical tests.
- **Scope.** The study was confined to Gauteng and to English-literate respondents. It measured intention rather than behaviour, and it measured the environment as perceived rather than as objectively verified.

7.11 Recommendations for future research

The findings and limitations suggest six directions for future research.

- **Longitudinal designs.** Panel studies that measure passion, self-efficacy, outcome expectations and intention at several points, and follow participants through to venture creation, would test the temporal sequence and reciprocal causation that this study could not observe. Belchior and Lyons (2021) demonstrate that such designs are feasible in this domain.
- **Indirect environmental pathways.** Future models should specify paths from role models, social support and socio-structural conditions to self-efficacy and outcome expectations, to test whether environmental influences reach intention through personal cognition, as the present correlation patterns suggest.
- **Larger and more diverse samples.** Samples large enough for confirmatory multi-group analysis, including young people outside the entrepreneurial pipeline and in rural provinces, are needed to test whether the dominance of passion and the absence of compensatory support hold across stages of entrepreneurial engagement and across regions.
- **Measurement development.** The multidimensional outcome expectation scale (material, social and self-evaluative) should be developed and validated for South African youth; socio-structural facilitators and impediments should be measured as separate constructs, and self-efficacy and passion measures should be refined to improve discriminant validity.

- **Cultural mechanisms.** Ubuntu, household redistributive obligations and proxy agency (Tornikoski et al., 2026) were used to interpret the South African context but were not measured. Future research should operationalise these constructs directly to test the cultural contingency arguments of Shayo (2023) and Kyriakopoulos et al. (2024).
- **Programme evaluation.** Quasi-experimental evaluations of entrepreneurship programmes that measure changes in passion and outcome expectations, building on Zwane and Osuigwe (2024), would establish whether interventions targeting these determinants raise intention and subsequent venture creation.

7.12 Concluding remarks

In this study, a research gap specific to the context was identified relating to personal and environmental determinants of entrepreneurial intention among youth in Gauteng province, South Africa. This study sought to identify the relationships between these determinants and intention, the mediation effect of self-efficacy, and the moderating effect of social support in the relationships using Social Cognitive Theory (SCT). It further sought to test the ability of an integrative model to explain and predict entrepreneurial intention.

It has been found that entrepreneurial passion was the strongest direct predictor of intention in the estimated model while outcome expectation was another independent predictor. While passion was significantly associated with self-efficacy, mediation by self-efficacy was not supported in the model. Role models, social support and perceived socio-structural facilitators did not demonstrate unique direct effects, and the hypothesised moderation and moderated mediation effects were not supported. The model explained 46.0% of the variance in entrepreneurial intention.

This study adds to the existing literature on SCT-based entrepreneurship studies by highlighting how the respective contributions of passion, self-efficacy, and outcome expectations could differ in a particular population and model. The study also reveals some relationships between the environmental and individual factors that need to be tested directly and not indirectly. The conclusions enhance the understanding of entrepreneurial intentions in this context but do not suggest that SCT is applicable only to a certain extent or that the observed relationship pattern will emerge in other populations.

The findings need to be considered in the context of the cross-sectional study design, small sample size of 114 respondents, non-probability sampling method,

measurement issues and focus on the participants already involved in entrepreneurship. Therefore, the conclusions cannot be generalised to the entire population of South African youth and used to make any assumptions about the influence of the studied variables on the venture creation process. Future research should use larger and more heterogeneous samples, longitudinal designs, better measurements and test the indirect environmental pathways directly, while investigating the relationship between the intention determinants and venture creation.

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